



From Garba Glam to Pandal Looks

Turn creator inspiration into festive business growth



Achieved **3x** more conversions with **YouTube Creator Partnerships Boost**



Drove **2.5x** higher video view-through rate with **YouTube Creator Partnerships Boost**



Leverage creator trust this festive season



Simulated UI for creative purposes. Results may vary. Some elements edited or created with AI

Drive festive business growth



89%

of viewers agree YouTube has **creator content** that helps them **research and discover** products, outperforming competitors¹



2.3x

YouTube drives 2.3x **incremental ROAS** compared to **social media**²



Leverage creator trust
this festive season



Sources:
1. Google/Kantar Future of Video Report, 2025
2. Equity-to-Sales MMM Meta Analysis commissioned by Google, 2021-2023

*Some elements edited or created with AI

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Name	Number of Equity Shares acquired	Face value per Equity Share (in ₹)	Weighted average price per Equity Share (in ₹)
Promoters			
Sandeep Kumar	Nil	10	Nil
Sunil Jallan	Nil	10	Nil
Krishan Kumar Jalan	Nil	10	Nil

Note: As certified by our Statutory Auditors vide certificate dated September 11, 2026 bearing UDIN 26077508ALL0ZF9199

17. The weighted average cost of acquisition of all shares transacted in (i) 1 year; (ii) 18 months and (iii) 3 years preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus is as follows:

Period	WACA (in ₹)	Cap Price is 'X' times the Weighted Average Cost of Acquisition	Range of acquisition price: lowest price – highest price (in ₹)
Last one (1) year preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus ¹	-	-	-
Last eighteen (18) months preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus	-	-	-
Last three (3) years preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus	44.55	9.09	Nil to 250

Note: As certified by our Statutory Auditors vide certificate dated September 11, 2026 bearing UDIN 26077508ALL0ZF9199

¹ There were no transactions in the last one year and 18 months

18. Details of price at which Equity Shares were acquired by our Promoters (also the selling shareholders), members of the Promoter Group and Shareholders with right to nominate directors or other rights in the last three years preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus:

Name of Shareholder	Date of acquisition	Number of Equity Shares acquired	Face Value (in ₹)	Acquisition price per Equity Share (in ₹) ¹	Nature of Transaction
Promoters					
Sandeep Kumar*	March 11, 2024	1,64,048	100	Nil	Allotment of equity shares pursuant to the scheme of amalgamation
	April 25, 2024	1,60,47,450	10	Nil	Bonus Issue
Sunil Jallan*	March 11, 2024	1,50,124	100	Nil	Allotment of equity shares pursuant to the scheme of amalgamation
	April 25, 2024	1,48,12,600	10	Nil	Bonus Issue
Krishan Kumar Jalan*	March 11, 2024	59,550	100	Nil	Allotment of equity shares pursuant to the scheme of amalgamation
	April 25, 2024	1,09,83,000	10	Nil	Bonus Issue
Promoter Group					
Daya Jalan	July 13, 2024	1,34,000	10	250.00	Private Placement
Santosh	July 13, 2024	30,000	10	250.00	Private Placement
Quality Stone and Steels	July 13, 2024	40,000	10	250.00	Private Placement

*As certified by our Statutory Auditors vide certificate dated September 11, 2026 bearing UDIN 26077508ALL0ZF9199

¹ Also the Selling Shareholders

Note: As on the date of the Red Herring Prospectus, there are no Shareholders with right to nominate directors or other special rights.

19. The 2 BRLMs associated with the Offer have handled 12 public issues in the past three years preceding the date of RHP, out of which 4 public issues closed below offer price on listing date.

Name of BRLMs	Main Board Issue	SME Issue	Total Issues	Issues closed below issue price on listing date
PL Capital Markets Private Limited	3	-	3	1
Khambatta Securities Limited	1	8	9	3

Note: No common Issues were handled by BRLMs.

Investors are advised to read the risk factors carefully before taking an investment decision in the Offer. For detail kindly refer “Risk Factors” beginning on page 31 of the RHP.

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION FOR INVESTORS

- The Company has not undertaken a pre-IPO placement from the date of the DRHP till date.
- The Promoter Selling Shareholders or members of the Promoter Group have not undertaken any transaction of Equity Shares aggregating up to 1% or more of the Paid-up Equity Share Capital of the Company from the date of the Draft Red Herring Prospectus till date.
- The aggregate Pre-offer and Post-offer shareholding of the Promoters, members of the Promoter Group and the additional top 10 Shareholders of the Company is set out below:

Sr. No.	Name of the Shareholders	Pre-Offer shareholding as on date of the Red Herring Prospectus		Post-Offer shareholding as on the date of Allotment ⁽ⁱ⁾			
		Number of Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 held	Percentage of the Equity Share capital (in %)	At the lower end of the price band (₹ 385)		At the upper end of the price band (₹ 405)	
				Number of Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 held	Percentage of the Equity Share capital (in %)	Number of Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 held	Percentage of the Equity Share capital (in %)
Promoters							
1	Sandeep Kumar*	2,24,66,430	32.81	2,19,46,950	28.25	2,19,72,603	28.45
2	Sunil Jallan*	2,07,37,640	30.29	2,02,18,160	26.02	2,02,43,813	26.21
3	Krishan Kumar Jalan*	1,53,76,200	22.46	1,51,16,460	19.46	1,51,29,287	19.59
Promoter Group							
1	Daya Jalan	1,34,000	0.2	1,34,000	0.17	1,34,000	0.17
2	Santosh	30,000	0.04	30,000	0.04	30,000	0.04
3	Quality Stone and Steels	40,000	0.06	40,000	0.05	40,000	0.05
Additional top 10 shareholders (other than our Promoters and Promoter Group)							
1	Goodluck India	4,00,000	0.58	4,00,000	0.51	4,00,000	0.52
2	Gauravraj Singh Vijaysingh Rathore	3,00,000	0.44	3,00,000	0.39	3,00,000	0.39
3	Saroj Vijaysingh Rathore	2,00,000	0.29	2,00,000	0.26	2,00,000	0.26
4	Ankur Garg	2,00,000	0.29	2,00,000	0.26	2,00,000	0.26
5	Faiguni Kapoor	2,00,000	0.29	2,00,000	0.26	2,00,000	0.26
6	Seven Alpha Investors Private Limited	1,98,105	0.29	1,98,105	0.25	1,98,105	0.26
7	Neetu Bansal	1,70,000	0.25	1,70,000	0.22	1,70,000	0.22
8	Ashutosh	1,55,000	0.23	1,55,000	0.20	1,55,000	0.20
9	Sheela Stainless Private Limited	1,50,000	0.22	1,50,000	0.19	1,50,000	0.19
10	Saket Agarwal	1,39,500	0.2	1,39,500	0.18	1,39,500	0.18
Other public shareholder							
1	Others	75,68,395	11.05	1,80,93,562	23.29	1,75,73,506	22.75
	Total	6,84,65,270	100	7,76,91,737	100	7,72,35,814	100

*Also, the Selling Shareholders

Notes:

- Assuming full subscription in the Offer (fresh issue and offer for sale). The post-offer shareholding details, as at allotment, will be based on the actual subscription and the final Offer Price and updated in the Prospectus, subject to finalization of the basis of allotment. Also, this table assumes there is no transfer of shares by these shareholders between the date of the advertisement and allotment (if any such transfers occur prior to the date of Prospectus, it will be updated in the shareholding pattern in the Prospectus).
- Based on the Offer price and subject to finalization of the basis of allotment.

BASIS FOR OFFER PRICE



The “Basis for Offer Price” beginning on page 219 of the RHP has been updated with the above. Please refer to the websites of the BRLMs: www.plindia.com and www.khambattasecurities.com respectively for the “Basis for Offer Price” updated with the above price band.

You may scan the QR code for accessing the website of PL Capital Markets Private Limited.

INDICATIVE TIMELINE IN RESPECT OF THE OFFER IS SET OUT BELOW:

Bid / Offer Programme	
Event	Indicative Date
Anchor Investor Bid/ Offer Period Opens and Closes On	Wednesday, September 23, 2026
Bid/ Offer Opens On	Thursday, September 24, 2026
Bid/ Offer Closes On	Monday, September 28, 2026 ⁽ⁱ⁾⁽ⁱⁱ⁾
Finalization of Basis of Allotment with the Designated Stock Exchange	On or about Tuesday, September 29, 2026
Initiation of refunds (if any, for Anchor Investors)/unblocking of funds from ASBA Account*	On or about Wednesday, September 30, 2026
Credit of Equity Shares to dematerialised accounts of Allottees	On or about Wednesday, September 30, 2026
Commencement of trading of the Equity Shares on the Stock Exchanges	On or about Thursday, October 1, 2026

⁽ⁱ⁾ Our Company may, in consultation with the BRLMs, consider closing the Bid/Offer Period for QIBs one Working Day prior to the Bid/Offer Closing Date in accordance with the SEBI/ICDR Regulations.

⁽ⁱⁱ⁾ UPI mandate end time and date shall be 5:00 p.m. on the Bid/Offer Closing Date.

*In case of (i) any delay in unblocking of amounts in the ASBA Accounts (including amounts blocked through the UPI Mechanism) exceeding two Working Days for cancelled/ withdrawn/ deleted ASBA Forms, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹ 100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher from the date on which the request for cancellation/ withdrawal/ deletion is placed in the Stock Exchanges bidding platform until the date on which the amounts are unblocked; (ii) any blocking of multiple amounts for the same ASBA Form (for amounts blocked through the UPI Mechanism), the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate ₹ 100 per day or 15% per annum of the total cumulative blocked amount except the original application amount, whichever is higher from the date of receipt of the investor grievance until the date on which the blocked amounts are unblocked; (iii) any blocking of amounts blocked more than the Bid Amount, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹ 100 per day or 15% per annum of the difference in amount, whichever is higher from the date on which such excess amounts were blocked till the date of actual unblock; (iv) any delay in unblocking of non-allotted/ partially allotted Bids, exceeding two Working Days from the Bid/Offer Closing Date, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹ 100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher for the entire duration of delay exceeding two Working Days from the Bid/Offer Closing Date by the SCSB responsible for causing such delay in unblocking. The BRLMs shall, in their sole discretion, identify and fix the liability on such intermediary or entity responsible for such delay in unblocking. The BRLMs shall be liable for compensating the Bidder at a uniform rate of ₹ 100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher from the date of receipt of the investor grievance until the date on which the blocked amounts are unblocked. The BRLMs shall, in their sole discretion, identify and fix the liability on such intermediary or entity responsible for such delay in unblocking.

The Bidder shall be compensated in the manner specified in the SEBI/ICDR Master Circular which for the avoidance of doubt, shall be deemed to be incorporated in the deemed agreement of the Company with the SCSBs, to the extent applicable.

The processing fees for applications made by UPI Bidders using the UPI Mechanism may be released to the remitter banks (SCSBs) only after such banks provide a written confirmation on compliance with SEBI/ICDR Master Circular.

Submission of Bids (Other than Bids from Anchor Investors):

Bid / Offer Period (except the Bid / Offer Closing Date)	
Submission and Revision in Bids	Only between 10.00 a.m. and 5.00 p.m. IST
Bid / Offer Closing Date*	
Submission Submission of Electronic Applications (Online ASBA through 3-in-1 accounts) For Retail Individual Bidders and Eligible Employees Bidding in the Employee Reservation Portion	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 5.00 p.m. IST
Submission of Electronic Applications (Bank ASBA through Online channels like Internet Banking, Mobile Banking and Syndicate UPI/ASBA applications where Bid Amount is up to ₹ 5.00 lakhs)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 4.00 p.m. IST
Submission of Electronic Applications (Syndicate Non-Retail, Non-Individual Applications)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 3.00 p.m. IST
Submission of Physical Applications (Bank ASBA)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 1.00 p.m. IST
Submission of Physical Applications (Syndicate Non-Retail, Non-Individual Applications of QIBs and NILs where Bid Amount is more than ₹ 5.00 lakhs)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 12.00 p.m. IST
Modification / Revision / Cancellation of Bids	
Upward Revision of Bids by QIBs and Non- Institutional Investors categories ^A	Only between 10.00 a.m. on the Bid/Offer Opening Date and up to 4.00 p.m. IST on Bid/Offer Closing Date
Modification/Upward or downward revision of Bids or cancellation of Bids by RILs and Eligible Employees Bidding in the Employee Reservation Portion	Only between 10.00 a.m. on the Bid/Offer Opening Date and up to 5.00 p.m. IST on Bid/Offer Closing Date

* UPI mandate end time shall be 5:00 p.m. on the Bid/Offer Closing Date

^A QIBs and Non Institutional Bidders can neither revise their bids downwards nor cancel/ withdraw their bids.

On the Bid/Offer Closing Date, the Bids shall be uploaded until:

- 4.00 p.m. IST in case of Bids by QIBs and Non-Institutional Bidders, and
 - until 5.00 p.m. IST or such extended time as permitted by the Stock Exchanges, in case of Bids by RILs and Eligible Employees Bidding in the Employee Reservation Portion.
- On Bid/Offer Closing Date, extension of time may be granted by the Stock Exchanges only for uploading Bids received by RIBs and Eligible Employees Bidding in the Employee Reservation Portion after taking into account the total number of Bids received and as reported by the Book Running Lead Managers to the Stock Exchanges.

ASBA *	Simple, Safe, Smart way of Application – Make use of it!!!	*Applications Supported by Blocked Amount (ASBA) is a better way of applying to Offers by simply blocking the fund in the bank account, investors can avail the same. For details, check section on ASBA below. Mandatory in Public Issues. No cheque will be accepted.
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UPI – Now available in ASBA for Retail Individual Investors and Non-Institutional Investors applying in public issues where the application amount is up to ₹ 5 Lakhs, applying through Registered Broker, Syndicate, CDPs & RTAs. UPI Bidders also have the option to submit the application directly to the ASBA Bank (SCSBs) or to use the facility of linked online trading, demat and bank account. Bidders are required to ensure that the bank account used for bidding is linked to their PAN. Bidders must ensure that their PAN is linked with Aadhar and are in compliance with CBDT notification dated February 13, 2020 issued by Central Board of Direct Taxes and the subsequent press releases, including press release dated June 25, 2021 read with press release dated September 17, 2021, and CBDT circular no. 7 of 2022 dated March 30, 2022, read with press release dated March 28, 2023 and any subsequent press release in this regard.

ASBA has to be availed by all the investors except Anchor Investors. UPI may be availed by (i) Retail Individual Investors; and (ii) Non-Institutional Investors applying in public issue where the application amount is up to ₹ 5 Lakhs in the Non-Institutional Portion. For details on the ASBA and UPI process, please refer to the details given in the Bid Cum Application Forms and Abridged Prospectus and also please refer to the section “Offer Procedure” beginning on page 730 of the RHP. The process is also available on the

website of Association of Investment Bankers of India (“AIBI”) and Stock Exchanges in the General Information Document. The Bid Cum Application Forms and the Abridged Prospectus can be downloaded from the websites of Stock Exchanges and can be obtained from the list of banks that is displaying on website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in/sebiweb/other/OtherAction.do?doRecognisedFpi=yes&intmid=35 and <https://www.sebi.gov.in/sebiweb/other/OtherAction.do?doRecognisedFpi=yes&intmid=43>, respectively as updated from time to time. For the list of UPI Apps and Banks live on IPO, please refer to the link: www.sebi.gov.in. UPI Bidders Bidding using the UPI Mechanism may apply through SCSBs and mobile applications whose names appear on the website of SEBI, as updated from time to time. HDFC Bank Limited and Axis Bank Limited have been appointed as Sponsor Bank for the Offer in accordance with the requirements of the SEBI Circular dated November 01, 2018, as amended. For Offer related queries, please contact the BRLM on its email ID as mentioned below. For UPI related queries, investors can contact NPCI at the toll free number: 18001201740 and mail ID: ipo.upi@npci.org.in

THE EQUITY SHARES OF OUR COMPANY WILL GET LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD PLATFORMS OF BSE AND NSE

In case of any revision to the Price Band, the Bid/Offer Period will be extended by at least three additional Working Days following such revision of the Price Band, subject to the Bid/Offer Period not exceeding 10 Working Days. In cases of force majeure, banking strike or similar unforeseen circumstances, our Company may, in consultation with the BRLMs, for reasons to be recorded in writing, extend the Bid/Offer Period for a minimum of one Working Day, subject to the Bid/Offer Period not exceeding 10 Working Days. Any revision in the Price Band and the revised Bid/Offer Period, if applicable, will be widely disseminated by notification to the Stock Exchanges, by issuing a public notice, and also by indicating the change on the respective websites of the BRLMs and the terminals of the Syndicate Members and by intimation to SCSBs, other Designated Intermediaries and the Sponsor Bank(s), as applicable.

This Offer is being made in terms of Rule 19(2)(b) of the SCRR read with Regulation 31 of the SEBI/ICDR Regulations. The Offer is being made through the Book Building Process and is in compliance with Regulation 6(1) of the SEBI/ICDR Regulations, wherein in terms of Regulation 32(1) of the SEBI/ICDR Regulations, not more than 50% of the Net Offer shall be allocated on a proportionate basis to QIBs, provided that our Company, in consultation with the BRLMs, may allocate up to 60% of the QIB Portion to Anchor Investors at the Anchor Investor Allocation Price on a discretionary basis in accordance with the SEBI/ICDR Regulations, of which 40% shall be reserved as follows: (i) 33.33% for domestic Mutual Funds; and (ii) 6.67% for Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds, subject to valid Bids being received from domestic Mutual Funds, Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds at or above the Anchor Investor Offer Price. In case the aggregate demand from Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds is less than 6.67%, the remaining Equity Shares will be added to the portion allocated to domestic Mutual Funds, in accordance with the SEBI/ICDR Regulations. In the event of under-subscription, or non-allotment in the Anchor Investor Portion, the balance Equity Shares shall be added to the Net QIB Portion. Further, 5% of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis only to Mutual Funds, and the remainder of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to all QIBs (other than Anchor Investors), including Mutual Funds, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price. Further, subject to availability of Equity Shares in the respective categories, not less than 15% of the Net Offer shall be available for allocation to Non-Institutional Bidders out of which (a) one third of such portion shall be reserved for applicants with application size of more than ₹ 20,00,000 and up to ₹ 10,00,000; and (b) two third of such portion shall be reserved for applicants with application size of more than ₹ 10,00,000, provided that the unsubscribed portion in either of such sub-categories may be allocated to applicants in the other sub-category of Non-Institutional Bidders and not less than 35% of the Net Offer shall be available for allocation to RIBs in accordance with the SEBI/ICDR Regulations, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price.

Furthermore, up to [•] Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 each, aggregating up to ₹ 200.00 lakhs shall be made available for allocation on a proportionate basis only to Eligible Employees Bidding in the Employee Reservation Portion, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price, if any, net of Employee Discount. The Employee Reservation Portion shall not exceed 5% of our post-offer paid-up equity share capital subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price, net of Employee Discount, if any. All Bidders (except Anchor Investors) are required to mandatorily utilize the Application Supported by Blocked Amount (“ASBA”) process by providing details of their respective ASBA Accounts and UPI ID (in case of UPI bidders using the UPI Mechanism (as defined hereinafter)), in which case the corresponding Bid Amounts will be blocked by the SCSBs or under the UPI Mechanism, as applicable to participate in the Offer. Anchor Investors are not permitted to participate in the Anchor Investor Portion of the Offer through ASBA process. For details, kindly refer “Offer Procedure” beginning on page 730 of the RHP.

Bidders/ Applicants should ensure that DP ID, PAN, Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI Mechanism) are correctly filled in the Bid cum Application Form. The DP ID, PAN and Client ID provided in the Bid cum Application Form should match with the DP ID, PAN, Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI Mechanism) available in the Depository database, otherwise, the Bid cum Application Form is liable to be rejected. Bidders/ Applicants should ensure that the beneficiary account provided in the Bid cum Application Form is active.

Bidders/Applicants should note that on the basis of the PAN, DP ID, Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI Mechanism) as provided in the Bid cum Application Form, the Bidder/Applicant may be deemed to have authorised the Depositories to provide to the Registrar to the Offer, any requested Demographic Details of the Bidder/Applicant as available on the records of the depositories. These Demographic Details may be used, among other things, for giving Allotment Advice or unblocking of ASBA Account or for other correspondence(s) related to the Offer. Bidders/Applicants are advised to update any changes to their Demographic Details as available in the records of the Depository Participant to ensure accuracy of records. Any delay resulting from failure to update the Demographic Details would be at the Bidders/Applicants’ sole risk.

Bidders must ensure that their PAN is linked with Aadhaar ID and are in compliance with CBDT notification dated February 13, 2020, press release dated June 25, 2021 and September 17, 2021, CBDT Circular no. 7 of 2022 dated March 30, 2022 and March 28, 2023 and any subsequent press releases in this regard.

CONTENTS OF THE MEMORANDUM OF ASSOCIATION OF OUR COMPANY AS REGARDS ITS OBJECTS: For information on the main objects and other objects of our Company, kindly refer “History and Certain Corporate Matters” beginning on page 406 of the RHP. The Memorandum of Association of our Company is a material document for inspection in relation to the Offer. For further details, kindly refer “Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection” beginning on page 794 of the RHP.

LIABILITY OF MEMBERS OF THE COMPANY: Limited by shares.

AMOUNT OF SHARE CAPITAL OF THE COMPANY AND CAPITAL STRUCTURE: As on date of RHP, the authorized share capital of the Company is ₹ 1,00,00,00,000 divided into 10,00,00,000 Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 each. The issued, subscribed and paid-up share capital of the Company before the Offer is ₹ 68,46,52,700 divided into 6,84,65,270 Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 each.

Basai Steels and Power Private Limited and A-One Gold Pipes and Tubes Private Limited are proposed to be amalgamated with our Company pursuant to a Scheme of Amalgamation under Sections 230 and 232 of the Companies Act, 2013, approved by the respective Boards on March 14, 2026. Pursuant to the Scheme, upon it becoming effective, our Company will issue 6,24,213 Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 each to the eligible shareholders of Basai Steels and Power Private Limited, based on the approved share exchange ratio of one Equity Share of our Company for every 413 equity shares of Basai Steels and Power Private Limited. Consequently, our paid-up equity share capital will increase from 6,84,65,270 Equity Shares to 6,90,89,483 Equity Shares. The Scheme is currently pending before the jurisdictional National Company Law Tribunals and, upon becoming effective, the transferor companies will stand dissolved without winding up. For details of the Capital Structure, kindly refer “Capital Structure” beginning on page 186 of the RHP.

NAMES OF THE INITIAL SIGNATORIES TO THE MEMORANDUM OF ASSOCIATION OF THE COMPANY AND THE NUMBER OF EQUITY SHARES SUBSCRIBED BY THEM: The names of the initial signatories of the Memorandum of Association of the Company are as follows: Sunil Kumar Jalan - 900 Equity Shares, Sandeep Kumar - 100 Equity Shares aggregating to 1,000 Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 100 each. For details of the share capital history of the Company, kindly refer “Capital Structure” beginning on page 186 of the RHP.

LISTING: The Equity Shares offered through the RHP are proposed to be listed on BSE and NSE. Our Company has received in-principle approvals from BSE and NSE for listing of the Equity Shares pursuant to their letters each dated April 16, 2025. For the purposes of this Offer, BSE shall be the Designated Stock Exchange. A signed copy of the RHP has been filed with the RoC and the Prospectus shall be filed with the RoC in accordance with Section 26(4) and 32 of the Companies Act, 2013. For details of the material contracts and documents available for inspection from the date of the RHP up to the Bid/Offer Closing date, kindly refer “Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection” beginning on page 794 of the RHP.

DISCLAIMER CLAUSE OF SECURITIES AND EXCHANGE BOARD OF INDIA (“SEBI”): SEBI only gives its observations on the Offer Documents and this does not constitute approval of either the Offer or the specified securities stated in the Offer Document. The investors are advised to refer to page 698 of the RHP for the full text of the Disclaimer Clause of SEBI.

DISCLAIMER CLAUSE OF BSE (THE DESIGNATED STOCK EXCHANGE): It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by BSE should not in any way be deemed or construed that the RHP has been cleared or approved by BSE nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the RHP. The investors are advised to refer to page 703 of the RHP for the full text of the Disclaimer Clause of BSE.

DISCLAIMER CLAUSE OF NSE: It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by NSE should not in any way be deemed or construed that the RHP has been cleared or approved by NSE nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the RHP. The investors are advised to refer to page 704 of the RHP for the full text of the Disclaimer Clause of NSE.

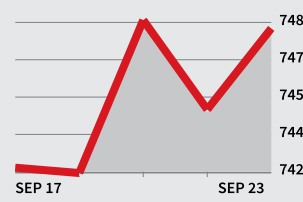
GENERAL RISKS: Investments in equity and equity-related securities involve a degree of risk and investors should not invest any funds in this Offer unless they can afford to take the risk of losing their investment. Investors are advised to read the risk factors carefully before taking an investment decision in this Offer. For taking an investment decision, investors must rely on their own examination of the Company and the Offer including the risks involved. The Equity Shares issued in the Offer have neither been recommended nor approved by Securities and Exchange Board of India (“SEBI”), nor does SEBI guarantee the accuracy or adequacy of the contents of the RHP. Specific attention of the investors is invited to the chapter titled “Risk Factors” beginning on page 31 of the RHP.

BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS

 PL CAPITAL MARKETS PRIVATE LIMITED 3rd Floor, Sadhana House 570, P.B. Marg, Worli Mumbai – 400 018, Maharashtra, India Telephone: +91 22 6632 2222; E-mail: aonesteelsipo@plindia.com Investor Grievance E-mail: grievance-nbd@plindia.com Contact Person: Narendra Gamini / Vansh Nishar Website: www.plindia.com SEBI Registration Number: INM000011237	 KHAMBATTA SECURITIES LIMITED 806, World Trade Tower, Tower B Sector-16, Noida – 201 301 Uttar Pradesh, India Tel.: +91 9953989693; 0120 4415469; E-mail: ipo@khambattasecurities.com Investor Grievance E-mail: mbcomplaints@khambattasecurities.com Contact Person: Chandan Mishra Website: www.khambattasecurities.com SEBI Registration Number: INM000011914
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REGISTRAR TO THE OFFER	COMPANY SECRETARY AND COMPLIANCE OFFICER
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IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23446.80	+117.80
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	19.87	+0.08
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.74	+0.15
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	151407.00	-120
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	232766.00	-156

CONTRA VIEW.

Zoho Founder Sridhar Vembu

plays down calls from frontier model makers to slow AI progress **p12**



TECHNOPHILE.

Samsung Galaxy S26 FE brings premium design and a whole suite of AI smarts, but high cost hurts appeal **p4**

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QUICKLY.

BACK AT NCLAT

Subhash Chandra contests order on assets alienation



New Delhi: Subhash Chandra has moved the appellate tribunal, NCLAT, against the order of a five-member Bench of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT), which restrained him from alienating his assets during the pendency of the matter. Meanwhile, the NCLT issued notice to the CBI saying the interim directive restraining the Essel Group Chairman from alienating property will continue until its final decision. **p11**

GOVERNMENT DIRECTIVE

PSBs, RRBs to function normally this Sunday

Mumbai: The Centre on Wednesday said all public sector banks (PSBs) and regional rural banks (RRBs) will function normally on September 27 (Sunday) so that banking needs of the public are not affected for an extended period due to the proposed three-day bank strike called by bank unions from September 28 to 30. **p5**

FSSAI cracks down on e-comm sites for misleading claims

PENAL ACTION. Platforms found selling, displaying prohibited or poisonous food items

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has initiated penal action against key e-commerce and quick commerce platforms for sale of products found to be allegedly non-compliant with regulations.

The food safety regulator on Wednesday said there has been “a major crackdown on e-commerce platforms including Amazon, Swiggy Instamart, BigBasket, Flipkart India and Zepto over regulatory non-compliances.”

In a social media post, the FSSAI said that “penal action” has been initiated for sale of products that were found to be misbranded or making misleading claims as well as for sale and display of prohibited or poisonous food articles through the platforms.

NON-COMPLIANT

The regulator pointed out that Happilo Premium Date Bites (Zesty Orange) and three products of Milky Mist, being sold on the platforms,

NON-COMPLIANCE

- Happilo, Milky Mist products found violating regulatory norms
- Amazon faces action for selling non-compliant Date Bites
- Amazon, Swiggy Instamart, BigBasket sold prohibited dhatura fruits illegally



were found to be non-compliant due to misleading and non-compliant claims and non-compliant product information. In the case of Amazon Seller Services, the FSSAI said that it has initiated penal action for the sale of Happilo Premium Date Bites (Zesty Orange) through its platform as it was found to be displaying misleading and non-compliant claims.

INITIATED ACTION

It has also initiated action against Flipkart India and Zepto for the sale of the same product. Also, for the sale of dhatura fruits and seeds on Amazon, which the regulator said was non-compliant with

provisions of the FSS Act, 2006, pertaining to sale, display and offer for sale through e-commerce platforms.

The food safety regulator said it has initiated penal action against Swiggy Instamart for sale of products through its platform which were found to be non-compliant with the regulations.

This includes Happilo Premium Date Bites (Zesty Orange), Milky Mist Fresh Low Fat Cream, Farm Fresh Curd and Greek Yoghurt, which were found to be displaying “misleading claims and non-compliant product claims”, it added.

The regulator also said that sale of dhatura seed or fruits through Instamart was in violation of its regulations.

Similarly, penal action has been initiated against BigBasket (Innovative Retail Concepts Pvt Ltd) for the sale of Happilo Premium Date Bites (Zesty Orange), Milky Mist’s products including Fresh Low Fat Cream, Farm Fresh Curd and Greek Yogurt besides dhatura fruits or seed, FSSAI’s social media post noted.

Front-of-the-pack warning soon

The FSSAI proposes to implement the front-of-the-pack warning labels framework with a single-phase approach, according to sources. Under the proposed framework, once implemented, food companies will be required to display front-of-the-pack warning labels if their products breach the prescribed threshold for any one ingredient of concern, which are added sugar, fat and salt. **p12**

IRDAI moots major overhaul of insurance distribution norms

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) has proposed a comprehensive framework of reforms covering insurance distribution, its structure, expenses, commissions, market conduct, transparency and leveraging digital infrastructure.

According to a public consultation paper on *Recalibrating Economics of Insurance Distribution* released on Wednesday, the regulator seeks to put in place a “customer-centric, competitive, efficient and transparent distribution ecosystem, while enabling better and sustainable outcomes for policyholders, insurers and distributors”.

EXPENSES

The expense of management (EoM) framework is proposed to be recalibrated through lower limits with a phased glide path. For life insurers, the EoM limit would move to a company-level basis linked to gross direct premium income (GDPI), with the limit proposed at 15 per cent within two years and 12.5 per cent within five years.

WHAT IT PROPOSES

- Eliminate scope for regulatory arbitrage
- Removal of restrictions on non-insurance business opportunities for intermediaries
- Ease up of entry and capital requirements
- Lower limits on expenses management
- Revision of commission norms

For general insurers, the basis would shift from gross written premium (GWP) to domestic gross direct premium income (GDPI), with the EoM limit reducing from 30 per cent of GWP to 20 per cent of GDPI within five years, also through progressive annual reductions.

REGULATORY FEE

The regulatory fee on insurers is also proposed to be reduced. The proposed reduction in EoM is intended to lower the overall cost of insurance, thereby expanding the risk pool available in general insurance and en-

hancing returns to policyholders in life savings products.

The phased approach seeks to balance improved value and affordability for policyholders with the financial sustainability of insurers, while progressively improving cost efficiency across the sector.

COMMISSIONS

The commission framework is proposed to be recalibrated in parallel. Instead of a uniform approach, commission limits would take into account the segment, line of business, distribution channel, product complexity and the effort involved in selling and servicing the product. The sale of products in under-served areas (small towns with population of up to 50,000 and rural areas, and smaller cities with population up to 10 lakh) may have rewards over and above the normal commission limits.

The proposals also include cost audits and safeguards against indirect payments with the objective of ensuring greater accountability for the actual cost of distribution. Greater transparency and stronger accountability are proposed to strengthen the ability of policyholders to make informed choices.

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S&P, Fitch, ADB, OECD raise India’s GDP forecast to around 7% for FY27

GROWTH FACTORS. Driven by strong industrial activity, resilient domestic demand and robust export goods

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

With good growth during April-June quarter and continued resilience amid West Asia crisis, S&P Global, Asian Development Bank (ADB), Fitch and OECD (Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development) on Wednesday raised India’s growth forecast for current fiscal to around 7 per cent.

This is higher than Reserve Bank of India forecast of 6.7 per cent. Last week Moody’s raised estimates to 7 per cent from 6 per cent.

In a report titled, ‘Economic Outlook Asia-Pacific Q4 2026: Exports, Domestic Demand Will Shore Up Growth,’ S&P Global said that several factors drove growth to higher levels than expected in the June quarter. These include robust industrial activity, healthy consumption, strong export goods, and accelerating government investment. “We have consequently upgraded our GDP growth forecast for the current fiscal year, ending March 31, 2027, to 7 per cent, from 6.6 per cent previously,” it said.



Meanwhile, S&P Global expects growth to ease in the second half of the fiscal year as the tailwinds from General Sales Tax rationalisation and income tax cuts diminish. Weather-related risks warrant close monitoring. It noted that cumulative rains were 15 per cent below normal till September 9 in the current monsoon season. Agricultural output and food inflation therefore remain key variables to watch,” it said.

ADB On Wednesday itself, ADB upgraded its gross domestic product (GDP) growth forecast for India to 7 per cent from 6.6 per cent for current fiscal. In the latest the Asian Development Outlook (ADO), the agency said the revision reflects India’s stronger-than-expected economic performance, with GDP expanding by 7.8 per cent year-on-year in the first quarter of fiscal year 2026-27, supported by robust in-

vestment demand, resilient consumption, and solid growth in manufacturing and service sectors.

“The economy has also benefited from lower-than-expected supply disruptions, sustained capital inflows, and limited pass-through of higher input cost increases to consumer prices which helped cushion the impact of the Middle East conflict,” the report said.

However, for next fiscal (2027-28), ADB now projects growth at 7.1 per cent, slightly lower than its earlier forecast of 7.3 per cent, largely reflecting a stronger GDP base.

FITCH Meanwhile, Fitch expects growth to moderate over the remainder of the financial year. PMI survey data point to a slower pace of expansion in both manufacturing and services; below-normal monsoon rains will weigh on growth in agriculture and rural demand; and rising inflation will constrain real incomes and consumer dynamics. Private investment prospects look more buoyant, and we expect investment to rise by more than 10

per cent; non-food credit growth reached 19 per cent in July.

“Overall GDP growth will be 6.9 per cent (revised up from 6.4 per cent in June),” it said while adding that growth will be steady in FY28, as the energy price shock unwinds.

“We expect GDP to rise by 6.5 per cent (a slight downward revision from June), with consumer spending and investment driving growth,” the agency said. External demand will hold up, with net exports contributing positively to growth (albeit to a lesser extent than in the current financial year).

OECD OECD raised India’s GDP growth projection for current fiscal by 80 basis points to 7.1 per cent citing resilient domestic demand and government policies that cushioned households and firms from the impact of higher energy prices.

It said that structural policy reforms that enhance the ability of economies to cope with supply-side disruptions are also a key priority for governments at the current juncture.

HDFC Bank topped dividend payout in FY26 at ₹21,000 cr

Sourashis Banerjee
Chennai

Among Nifty 500 companies, HDFC Bank distributed nearly ₹21,000 crore as dividends in FY26. SBI and HCL Technologies followed with ₹16,015 crore and ₹14,621 crore, respectively.

Yet, high absolute payouts didn’t translate into high dividend yields, showed a *businessline* analysis.

DATA FOCUS.

Nearly half of the Nifty 500 companies had yields below 1 per cent, while only a relatively small group of 13 companies offered yields above 5 per cent as of September 17, 2026 based on FY26 dividends.

NUMBER CRUNCHING Banks accounted for the largest sectoral dividend payout in FY26, with 23 lenders distributing ₹71,858 crore. Mining followed with ₹34,359 crore from five companies, while eight petroleum refineries and distributors paid out ₹25,163 crore.

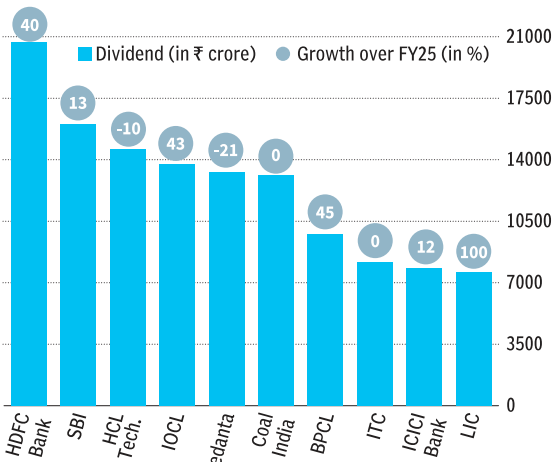
“The improvement in bank asset quality, moderation in credit costs and stronger profitability, along with comfortable capital buffers, have increased banks’ ability to distribute surplus capital while continuing to support credit growth in FY26,” said Ajit Mishra, Senior Vice-President - Research, Religare Broking.

In FY26, HDFC Bank increased dividend by 40 per cent over FY25, while SBI’s payout rose 13 per cent. LIC’s dividend payout doubled during the period.

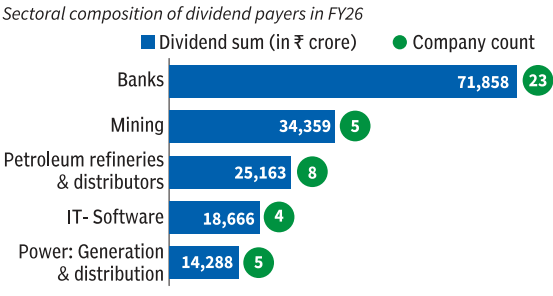
In contrast, Vedanta’s dividend fell 21 per cent and HCL Technologies’ declined 10 per cent. “HCLTech’s lower FY26 dividend appears more earnings-linked than policy-driven. FY26 PAT was at ₹17,361 crore vs ₹17,390

Payouts

HDFC Bank, SBI paid the highest dividend in FY26
Nifty500 companies dividend payouts in FY26



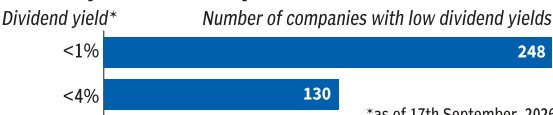
Banks gave the highest dividends, followed by mining and petroleum companies dominated by PSUs



Vedanta has the highest dividend yield in FY26



Nifty 500 is dominated by companies with very low dividend yields



Source:Capitaline

*as of 17th September, 2026

OMCs under pressure as West Asia conflict prolongs: ICRA

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The PSU oil marketing companies (OMCs) are facing the dual challenge of procuring barrels amidst supply disruptions and volatile prices, which coupled with no change in retail prices of diesel, petrol and LPG is leading to margin erosion and losses.

Rating agency ICRA estimates that marketing margins

are at a negative of ₹8 per litre on petrol and ₹9 a litre on diesel. Besides, the domestic LPG under-recoveries are at ₹300 per cylinder in September. This is due to the recent spike in international crude oil prices amidst domestic retail prices of the downstream fuels remaining unchanged.

Prashant Vasisht, Senior V-P and Co-Group Head of Corporate Sector Ratings at ICRA, pointed out that escalation of the West Asian conflict

and disruptions to key oil supply routes have led to a spike in crude prices in recent weeks, resulting in sizeable marketing losses and LPG under-recoveries for OMCs.

“With domestic retail prices remaining unchanged so far, the marketing margins of OMCs were estimated at negative ₹8 per litre on petrol and negative ₹9 on diesel, while domestic LPG under-recoveries stood at around ₹300 per cylinder in September. At

these levels, the daily loss to the OMCs is estimated at ₹530 crore,” he said at a media briefing.

Crude oil prices rose sharply in recent weeks on account of escalating geopolitical tensions and supply disruptions in West Asia. The surge was driven by renewed US-Iran conflict, shutdown of Saudi Arabia’s East-West pipeline and heightened Houthi activities in the Red Sea. The Indian crude basket

rose to \$117.4 per barrel on September 21, 2026 from the 2025-26 average of around \$66. The cumulative negative LPG buffer increased sharply to ₹61,940 crore as on June 30, 2026, as the rise in international LPG prices following the West Asian supply disruptions was not fully passed on to consumers, ICRA said.

The estimated loss per domestic cylinder stood at around ₹500 in Q1 and remained at ₹300 in September.

Modi’s likely visit to Canada in December adds urgency to free trade negotiations

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s expected visit to Canada in December has added momentum to the ongoing India-Canada free trade agreement negotiations as both sides prepare for the upcoming round early next month that could be crucial in pushing the talks towards conclusion, sources said.

“With the Prime Minister likely to visit Canada in December, the two sides are inclined to push the talks towards an early conclusion. The Commerce Ministry has been engaging with the industry on inputs on protecting sensitivities as well as ensuring adequate market access for goods and services in Canada. The fifth round of negotiations will be crucial,” a source tracking the matter said.

FIFTH ROUND OF TALKS

The Indian negotiating team will be in Canada for the fifth round of Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) or FTA negotiations on October 5



Prime Minister Narendra Modi

and there were efforts to fast-track the talks, Commerce & Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said last week. Both countries are looking at doubling bilateral trade in goods and services to \$50 billion by 2030.

The push to advance the negotiations comes amid heightened geopolitical uncertainty and the evolving US tariff regime under US President Donald Trump, which have added to the urgency for both countries to strengthen trade ties and diversify markets and supply chains. India already implemented its FTA with the UK in July this year and has announced that its pact with New Zealand will kick off from October 20. Indicating

that the India-Canada CEPA could conclude by the year-end, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney said on Tuesday that he and the Indian PM had committed at the G20 meet last year to look to conclude negotiations by the G20 this year, which was slated in December.

“I believe that India just confirmed that the Prime Minister will be visiting Canada around that time. The precise date isn’t out, but I very much look forward to hosting him,” Carney said addressing reporters on the sidelines of the United Nations General Assembly high-level session.

The Canadian Prime Minister added that the two sides were making good progress in the negotiations.

Both sides will try to sort out the remaining tricky issues, including Canada’s demand for market access in farm products and India’s insistence on more visas for its professionals and removal of non-tariff barriers including technical barriers to trade, in the upcoming round, the source noted.

India wants Canada to

ease some of its restrictive or burdensome technical regulations, standards, or product safety requirements, including packaging and labelling requirements, an industry source pointed out.

India-Canada bilateral trade in goods was at \$8 billion in 2025-26, while India’s exports to the country were at \$4.67 billion, per government figures.

Major items of India’s exports to Canada include pharmaceutical products, machinery parts & mechanical appliances, iron & steel articles, electronic goods, organic chemicals, jewellery, gems & precious stones, clothing & textile articles, seafood, engineering goods and auto parts. India’s major imports from Canada include pulses, fertilisers (potash), mineral fuels, wood pulp, gems & precious stones (diamonds), aircraft parts, machinery parts, paper & paperboard and iron & aluminium scrap.

India’s main services sector exports include telecommunications, computer and information services, and other business services.

Transfer pricing disputes ‘disproportionately’ burden developing nations: FM Sitharaman

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Wednesday said transfer pricing disputes “disproportionately” burden developing countries, as India advocated for setting up two new BRICS working groups dedicated to taxation.

Addressing a meeting of the BRICS heads of Tax authorities, Sitharaman said the meeting will look at the scoping documents for two new working groups — on international taxation and

transfer pricing, and on revenue statistics. “Transfer pricing disputes cost developing-country administrations disproportionately. Revenue frameworks that don’t fit our fiscal realities distort how we are seen and how we see ourselves. These Working Groups exist because every country in this room has experienced these problems,” Sitharaman said.

The Minister added that the working groups would create sustained institutional space for progress over time, regardless of who holds the Chair.

“They are designed to out-

last India’s Chairship,” Sitharaman said. China will take over the rotating BRICS Presidency in 2027.

The Minister further said that the rules of international taxation are being renegotiated through several multilateral tax negotiations, including the UN Framework Convention on International Tax Cooperation, under active negotiation.

“The decisions made in these processes over the next few years will shape cross-border taxation for a generation,” Sitharaman said.

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TECH DIGEST.

Amazon launches the all-new Alexa+ in India

Amazon has launched the all-new Alexa+, Amazon's generative AI-powered personal assistant in India. Alexa+ is pitched as a conversational, smarter, deeply personalised digitally companion that is also ready for Indian households. You can intuitively control your smart home with devices from brands like Atomberg, Qubo, and Wipro. You can also play and discover music, podcasts, and films in different ways —such as by mood, activity, or description on apps like Amazon Music, Spotify, Apple Music, Prime Video, and Netflix. During our first interactions with Alexa+ we saw these experiences come together seamlessly. Alexa+ is built on Amazon Bedrock, leveraging an all-new architecture that connects over 70 large language models. Alexa+ will be free for all customers during Early Access, from September 2026 After Early Access ends, Alexa+ will stay free for Prime plan members. Alexa is available for access on eligible Echo smart speakers and smart displays, Fire TV streaming devices, and the Alexa mobile app.

Qualcomm unveils new Snapdragon 8 Elite chips

Qualcomm has introduced the Snapdragon 8 Elite Extreme Gen 6 and Snapdragon 8 Elite Gen 6 at Qualcomm's Snapdragon Summit in Maui, Hawaii, on September 22. The Snapdragon 8 Elite Extreme Gen 6 introduces support for more agentic AI workloads on smartphones. It also features Adreno Neural Fusion, which uses AI for graphics processing in mobile games, along with camera enhancements including Advanced Professional Video (APV) support and Intelligent Pixel Control. The Snapdragon 8 Elite Gen 6 is based on the same 2nm process and uses Qualcomm's custom Oryon CPU, Adreno GPU and Hexagon NPU. It supports many of the AI, gaming, imaging and connectivity capabilities available on the Extreme variant, while targeting a wider range of premium smartphones. Qualcomm said smartphones using the two chipsets are expected from several manufacturers, including Honor, iQOO, Motorola, Nubia, OnePlus, OPPO, REDMI, RedMagic, vivo, Xiaomi and ZTE.

Snap introduces AI service, SPECS Intelligence

Snap Inc has introduced SPECS Intelligence, an AI service that uses connected apps to provide contextual suggestions across iPhone, Mac and SPECS AR glasses. SPECS Intelligence is designed to surface information and suggested actions when relevant. For example, it can provide meeting preparation or bring together travel details while highlighting schedule conflicts and deadlines. On SPECS glasses, users can access contextual information such as schedules, reservations and reminders within their field of view. Snap says users can choose which accounts and information are connected. According to the company, personal content from connected accounts will not be used to train its AI models or serve personalised advertising. An invitation-only early-access version is being offered through the SPECS Mac app. A separate iOS preview is available to users aged 18 and above in the US, allowing them to connect Gmail and Google Calendar to generate insights about how they spend their time. The mobile preview does not include the service's anticipatory suggestions or actions.

ASUS offers 3 months of Google AI plans in India

ASUS has announced a Google AI offer for select ASUS and ROG laptop customers in India, providing three months subscription of Google AI Pro or Google AI Plus. The offer applies to new and existing customers with eligible devices. Google AI Pro includes 5TB of cloud storage, while Google AI Plus includes 400GB. Depending on the plan and market availability, users can access Google AI services including the Gemini app, Deep Research, Google Flow and Gemini in Google apps. The tools cover use cases such as research, content creation, productivity and development. Google AI Pro also includes access to select developer and agentic tools, subject to the relevant plan terms and availability. The offer covers selected 2025 and 2026 ASUS laptops, as well as eligible upcoming 2027 models, across the ROG, TUF Gaming, ProArt, Zenbook and Vivobook product lines. The programme runs from August 10, 2026, to August 9, 2027. Eligible customers in India can redeem the three-month subscription through the MyASUS app, with availability depending on the device, plan and applicable terms.

Premium economy gets pricier in 2026

SAMSUNG GALAXY S26 FE. Premium design, gorgeous display and a whole suite of AI smarts is packed in Samsung Galaxy S26

Ashwin Rajagopalan

I've often thought of Samsung's FE (Fan Edition) series as the smartphone equivalent of flying premium economy. You get some of the trappings of a business class cabin, like extra legroom and a better menu choice, yet it's still not as luxurious as the front of the cabin. Flight fares are scaling new highs in 2026 thanks to rising fuel costs: economy fares on most days are now higher than what we used to pay on premium economy seats back in 2025. The smartphone industry has run into headwinds of its own, with increased RAM and input costs forcing brands to increase prices across the board. Cut to 2025, the Samsung Galaxy S25 FE debuted at a launch price of ₹59,999, serving as a bridge between Samsung's A series smartphones and the flagship S25 series. The S26 FE has just dropped at a launch price of ₹79,999, a significant 33 per cent year-on-year jump. It's an increase necessitated by the times, and it raises a more important question: who's the FE series for?

DESIGN If there's a moment of truth in the journey of a smartphone, it's that second when you first hold a smartphone that you've seen on your Instagram feed or a commercial. It's a moment that the S26 FE won in my experience. I felt even better in my hand than I anticipated. It's a tough win for most smartphone brands, because it combines multiple variables such as tactile finishes, ergonomics and the overall fit and finish. The FE is marginally thicker and heavier than the Galaxy S26+. It felt lighter in my hand than the 193 g heft in the spec sheet. You won't miss a Galaxy S series device when it comes to design. The S26 FE is crafted with a durable Armour aluminium frame complemented by Corning Gorilla Glass Victus+ protection on the front and the rear of the device. Samsung has opted for a glossy back (the S25 FE featured a matte finish) that plays out well in the pistachio colour variant that we checked out. You might encounter fingerprints and smudges in the darker colourways –



FE EVOLUTION. The S26 FE comes with an Exynos 2500 chipset, complemented by a 50MP primary camera great photography ASHWIN RAJAGOPALAN

Blueberry and Graphite. The ingress protection also puts the S26 FE in a premium band with an IP68 rating for dust and water resistance.

DISPLAY The S26 FE retains the same display that we saw on last year's S25 FE. You get a gorgeous 6.7-inch Dynamic AMOLED 2X display (1080 x 2340 pixels) with a 120 Hz refresh rate and a peak brightness of 1900 nits. Colours are vibrant and the display offers good visibility across lighting conditions. I watched an episode of the French show *Summer '36* on Netflix, and the display captured the mood of the French Riviera in the 1930s with excellent colour reproduction. It supports high-definition streaming and HDR content on Netflix. The dual speaker setup is also similar to the S25 FE and offers a well-balanced audio experience.

CAMERA The rear camera is one area where the gap between the flagship S26 (and S26+) is more obvious. This is particularly true in the case of low-

light images and ultrawide shots. The 50MP primary lens does a great job, particularly in optimal light. The 8MP telephoto lens produced good results up to 3x. The S26 FE also performs well on the portrait camera front with clear background separation. I'd recommend switching to night mode when you shoot in low light rather than shooting with the standard mode. The camera also benefits from Samsung's camera tools like My FanCam and Photo Assist. The S26 FE delivers images and videos that are good enough for your social media feed, but you might need one of Samsung's flagships if you are looking to use pro mode.

PERFORMANCE At the heart of the S26 FE is an Exynos 2500 chipset built on a 3 nm process, complemented by 8 GB of RAM and 256 GB of internal storage. It's one of the key upgrades over the S25 FE, which is powered by the 4nm Exynos 2400 processor. This new chipset impacts everything from battery life to everyday performance. The device consistently

notched up scores above 7400 in our Geekbench (multi-core) benchmark test that puts it in a league below the flagship S series. This is one of the areas where the S26 FE lives up to its branding as a bridge device with a performance that should please most everyday users and also work for gamers.

The device runs on One UI 9 that is built on Android 17. Samsung offers 7 generations of OS updates, which is a great feature at this price and in line with the update policy of its flagship smartphones. Battery life is quite solid too; it should be a one-day battery for most users with extensive screen time. The 4,900 mAh battery powers up in quick time with support for 45W wired charging and 15W wireless charging. The device offers the convenience of reverse wireless charging via Samsung's Wireless Power Share.

VERDICT Samsung's FE smartphone for 2026 doesn't reinvent the wheel. There are a couple of iterative upgrades (like the processor) and some surprising downgrades over the S25

FE, like the USB data transfer (down from USB 3.2 Gen 1 to USB 2.0). The S26 FE hits the right notes on the design and display front with a rear camera that won't let you down. While there's a lot to like about this smartphone, the ₹20,000 price hike over last year's FE is bound to create conundrums for customers. Should you spend the extra money and buy the Samsung Galaxy S26 for a better camera and performance? Should you look for last year's S25 or S25 FE that are still quite future-proof? While the S26 FE sticks to the same script as some of Samsung's recent FE devices, the smartphone industry dynamics in 2026 make it a challenging market for the S26 FE.

● SNAPSHOT

Price: ₹79,999 onwards
Pros: Premium design, good display, AI tools, seven years of Android updates
Cons: Iterative upgrade, significant increase in price.

Does Sony build a case for open-ear earbuds?

SONY LINKBUDS CLIP. The device promises to make an impact in the realm of audio devices by blending functionality with fashion

Ashwin Rajagopalan

In a world where TWS Bluetooth earbuds have become ubiquitous, open-ear earbuds offer a refreshingly new user experience. As the name suggests, this emerging gadget category is designed to provide an alternative to users who find conventional TWS earbuds inconvenient. Ask TWS buds users who are on frequent calls and need to listen to music for a couple of hours a day, and you might hear complaints about a tight ear canal fit or the lack of situational awareness. That's a problem for commuters on a metro, cycling enthusiasts or late morning runners. We've seen launches from brands like Bose, Nothing and Sony, all of which are adopting contrasting design and sound approaches. Sony has pitched the LinkBuds Clip as a significant improvement over the first-gen LinkBuds. After two weeks with these buds, I believe Sony might be on to something.

DESIGN Get ready for some attention. The LinkBuds Clip are very likely to make heads turn thanks to their unique and unconventional design. Most people might mistake them for a fashion accessory, especially if you opt for the lavender or green colour options. These earbuds are essentially minute speakers that are attached to a C-shaped clip. This clip connects two parts – a tiny speaker pod that rests inside your ear's concha and a battery barrel that hides behind your ear. The case is thicker (it weighs 42 g without the buds) than most standard cases. It might remind you of a ring box or two slim cases stacked together. It will slip comfortably into most trouser and jeans pockets but might be a tight squeeze for skinny jeans. The buds are designed to sit comfortably inside the case. Each LinkBuds Clip earbud weighs 6.4 g. I never felt the weight, even after hours of use. It's easy to forget that they're strapped on to your ears until a curious friend or stranger asks about the accessory



CLIP-ON. Sony's new audio device features a clip-on type design, offering balanced sound and clear call quality ASHWIN RAJAGOPALAN

that's clipped on to your ear. They also sat quite securely in my ears through brisk walks and gym workouts. They are also designed to work for people who wear glasses. Not all ears are the same size; it's why the retail box includes a set of colour-matched silicone air-fitting cushions for a secure fit for users with smaller ears. While the buds

have an IPX4 rating—meaning you're covered for sweat and light rain—the case is unrated for any moisture or water protection.

USER EXPERIENCE The setup is a breeze. I paired these buds with an iPhone and a Samsung smartphone. I used Sony's Sound Connect app on the iPhone to ex-

plore the settings. The cuff offers tap gestures, and they generally worked well. The app is fairly intuitive and offers quite a few customisations. There is a 'Scene' menu for your frequent routines such as commutes, gym workouts and walking. There are voice cues that include time announcements (that you can turn off). Spotify Tap is a handy feature if Spotify is your primary music platform and allows you to control your Spotify experience with pre-programmed taps.

SOUND This is the biggest change you're likely to experience if you're making the switch from TWS earbuds or over-ear headphones. You will never get the same acoustics or isolation that you experience on conventional headphones. This is a clear trade-off if you're looking for a less intrusive experience (especially in the case of TWS earbuds that fit directly into the ear). Active noise cancellation (ANC) on conventional headphones allows you to enjoy a very similar music experience, irrespective of the environment you're in. It's not the same with these buds; the overall experience varies drastically depending on your surroundings. Sony offers a very refined music experience with a whole bunch of customisations. You have a choice of four listening modes, including a 'sound leakage reduction' option that ensures that the music from the LinkBuds Clip doesn't disturb people around you. When listening to the thumping electronic beats and club-ready builds on Madonna's *Love Sensation*, I experienced very different outcomes in different listening modes – the standard mode worked best for this song. Sony also offers various equaliser settings to complement the listening modes. The Voice Boost mode worked best for podcasts. While the overall experience worked best in quieter environments, these buds may not be ideal for gyms with loud music or airplane cabins with the constant hum of engines or fellow passengers who think headphones are optional while they catch up on videos.

The Sony Link Buds Clip worked really well for calls. Sony has added dual microphones with features like precise voice pickup and AI-based signal processing to give calls a boost. My callers could hear me clearly even in loud environments.

BATTERY LIFE Sony claims nine hours of battery life on a single charge, with the case providing an additional 28 hours (adding up to 37 hours). Actual results might vary depending on sound settings and use case scenarios. You can expect about seven-eight hours on average with a mix of calls and loud music. Battery life is quite impressive, but we wish Sony had added wireless charging for the case. It's a feature most buyers expect at this price point.

VERDICT Sony makes a strong case for open-ear earbuds with the Sony LinkBuds Clip. Open-ear earbuds work really well for certain segments of users for whom situational awareness matters the most. You may not miss your conventional headphones. The LinkBuds Clip also scores with their comfort, which is great if your daily routines involve frequent calls. Sony delivers one of the best acoustic experiences in this category and handles calls with ease. Open-ear earbuds may complement your existing headphones. You might use these buds when you go for a run or cycle but might go back to your over-ear headphones or earbuds with ANC for the gym or flight cabins. If you're sold on open-ear earbuds, the LinkBuds Clip ought to be on your radar.

● SNAPSHOT

Price: ₹18,990
Pros: Unique design, comfortable, good acoustic experience, good for calls
Cons: Not suitable for loud environments, no wireless charging.

Future tense

China-India ties in a renewed state of flux

In a month marked by high profile bilateral meets and multilateral exchanges, China’s President Xi Jinping’s visit to India after seven years has drawn considerable attention. India’s engagement with China has always been intriguing, tense, multi-faceted, and yet driven by a sense of pragmatism. As a result, bilateral ties go through frequent highs and lows; while the trade and engagement remains deep, China gets



sive along the border from time to time es India by collaborating with Pakistan. A thaw that came into being four years after the Galwan clash in 2020 has receded. Tensions have hardened on China’s provocation and on two fronts. While China regards Arunachal Pradesh as ‘South Tibet’ and has encroached into a part of the State, it has also entered into a dubious border deal with Pakistan in the PoK region, disregarding India’s rightful claim on that area. China’s incursion in Arunachal Pradesh marks a setback to the joint patrolling arrangement agreed upon in October 2024 along the Line of Actual Control. India has unequivocally expressed its displeasure. As reported by this newspaper recently, India has said that it will not provide China any trade or investment concessions unless China stops its aggression at the border. Coming as it does six months after the government relaxed its Press Note 3 curbs on Chinese investment into India, the message is clear.

While PN 3 was relaxed in March this year to allow minority Chinese investment of up to 10 per cent, China might have entertained thoughts of further concessions at a time when India is faced with fickle capital flows. The Chinese should know that they cannot access the Indian market by undermining national interest. The government has taken the right position by linking the border issue with trade and investment ties. A tendency to separate the two gives China the leeway to inflict harm on India. China should be reined in, where managing common waters is concerned. As for leverage, India may be dependent on Chinese intermediates and critical minerals for its electronics, solar, automobiles and pharma sectors, but China, too, eyes India’s large market to offset the paucity of domestic demand back home amidst huge overcapacities.

Yet, with the bilateral trade deficit at \$131 billion in FY26, up about 16 per cent from FY25, India must urgently develop domestic capabilities across value chains to deal with a hegemonic neighbour — who is also a leading trade partner — on our terms. A 40 per cent jump in India’s exports to China in April-August FY27 could just be the beginning. Bilateral ties will remain challenging, while being influenced by US actions. President Trump’s weaponisation of tariffs has, in fact, opened up space for making common cause on multilateral issues. China, more than ever, sees itself as a countervailing force, and a voice for the Global South in contested areas of trade and technology. India’s multi-alignment would serve it well against the two powers.

POCKET RAVIKANTH



SANKALPA BHATTACHARJEE

On February 20, the Supreme Court ruled 6-3 in *Learning Resources vs Trump* that the International Emergency Economic Powers Act did not authorise Trump to impose tariffs. Congress has since supplied what the Court found missing: the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026 — passed 86-11 in the Senate, 262-159 in the House, and now signed into law — authorises tariffs of up to 100 per cent on the five largest importers of Russian oil and gas. For India, the second-largest buyer of Russian crude after China, that makes this graver than last August’s tariff shock: the threat is now statute, not something a court can strike down.

THE ARITHMETIC OF EXPOSURE India imports over 88 per cent of its crude, and in July 2026 alone, Russia supplied \$7.27 billion of India’s \$14.21 billion crude import bill — \$1.1 per cent, comfortably ahead of the UAE’s 10.8 per cent and Saudi Arabia’s 9.6 per cent. That dependence survived February 2026’s pact that cut India’s tariff burden from 50 to 18 per cent, partly in exchange for a pledge to diversify away from Russian crude. Yet, FY26 purchases of US oil reached just \$9.87 billion, against a \$40.82 billion Russian import bill. India simultaneously has significant exposure to the American market. Merchandise exports to the US rose to \$87.31 billion in FY26 – 19.78 per cent of India’s exports and a \$33.86 billion bilateral surplus — led by electrical machinery (\$25.68 billion), pharmaceuticals (\$8.67 billion), nuclear reactors (\$7.19 billion), gems and jewellery (\$5.12 billion), and minerals (\$3.52 billion). Goldman Sachs puts India’s total goods-and-services exposure to the US at roughly 4 per cent of GDP; ICRIFER estimates 7.38 per cent of exports are materially at risk.

WHERE IT REALLY BITES HARD The export story gets the attention, but India’s more fragile flank is its external account, which a tariff shock would hit from two directions at once. Q1 FY27’s current account deficit was \$4.2 billion, just 0.5 per cent of GDP, but the merchandise trade deficit beneath it widened to \$86.1 billion. A tariff-induced export slump would widen that gap mechanically. Feeding it from the other side: Brent crossed \$100 a barrel on September 9, pushing India’s own crude basket to \$113.91, and India’s net oil and gas import bill jumped 36.5



GETTY IMAGES

How India can counter the Graham Act

WAY AHEAD. As the tariffs can hit exports, India must reduce dependence on Russian oil, conclude the bilateral trade deal with the US quickly, and widen the export market

per cent year-on-year to over \$60 billion during April-August, 2026. Every \$10 rise in Brent is reckoned to shave 20-30 basis points off GDP growth — a drag that operates whether or not Washington ever pulls the tariff trigger. The reserve cushion reassures only at a glance. Reserves hit a lifetime high of \$785.7 billion in the week to September 4 – a record \$44.9 billion jump — but a large share is not export earnings; it is the RBI’s concessional swap window, which pulled in over \$136 billion in borrowed foreign-currency deposits since June. The rupee, meanwhile, touched a record low of 96.84 on May 20, **The Act offers India more room than the headline rate suggests: tariffs capped at the top five importers, with carve-outs for ‘significant’ diversification to reduce Russian energy dependence**

and is still hovering above 95 to the dollar. A reserve buffer built substantially on rented dollars is a thinner shock absorber than the headline suggests — precisely when a tariff-driven export slump would test it. **CANNOT BANK ON WASHINGTON** The Act offers India more room than the headline rate suggests: tariffs capped at the top five importers, with carve-outs for “significant” diversification to reduce Russian energy dependence. The same administration that raised India’s tariff to 50 per cent in August 2025 also reduced it to 18 per cent within six months, suggesting the lever is calibrated for bargaining rather than functioning as fixed law. India’s response on September 17 was accordingly measured, not defiant, reaffirming diversification rather than threatening retaliation — the diplomatic equivalent of waiting the lever out. **THE WAY FORWARD** Washington’s discretion is not something India can rely on. Four steps

matter more than hoping for restraint. First, conclude the bilateral trade agreement — seven months overdue — at preferential, not reciprocal, rates: a negotiated floor beats a revocable concession. Second, treat the reserve buffer as a war chest, not a trophy — a swap-financed cushion needs genuine surplus behind it, not applause, before the next bout of rupee pressure. Third, diversify crude sourcing for real, not the token shift that has kept Russia’s share above 50 per cent — that earns the Act’s own “significant steps” exemption, rather than betting on presidential goodwill. Fourth, widen export markets beyond a US corridor that has delivered two tariff shocks in thirteen months — concentration, not merely this law, is the risk. Strategic autonomy was never freedom from constraints; it is the capacity to prevent any single constraint from dictating policy.

The writer teaches Economics at IIM Ranchi. Views are personal

When tech takes a backseat in serving humanity

The race for artificial intelligence undermines the human role that gives technology its social purpose

Saumitra Bhaduri As the world watches the unfolding of the \$18 billion settlement against Meta in California, something larger than a dispute over Facebook and Instagram is taking shape. The case, which began on August 18, has been brought by attorneys general from 29 US states, alleging that Meta deliberately designed its platforms to be addictive to children, concealed evidence of harm and violated laws protecting children’s privacy. The states are seeking not just a compensation, but fundamental changes to how social media operates its platforms. What makes the case particularly significant is not simply the number of states involved. It is the fact that the state itself has become the plaintiff. This is not an individual claiming that social media harmed him or her. It is the government asserting that a technology company’s business model can create a social harm. US governments, along with many others, have begun to treat artificial intelligence itself as a matter of national security and public policy.

DOOMSDAY SCENARIOS Why this sudden awakening? The obvious explanations are familiar. There are concerns about children, misinformation, privacy, job displacement, cybersecurity, national security and the more dramatic doomsday scenarios surrounding AI.

However, the deeper issue is more fundamental: what do we expect technology to do for humanity? There is no single definition of technology. Nonetheless, one could zero in on an intuitive definition: technology is the practical application of human knowledge, ideas and skills to create tools, machines and systems that solve problems, make work more efficient and improve human life. Two common elements deserve attention: first, technology solves problems, and second, it improves the quality of human life. Think of any technology, and it will satisfy both. Medical technologies seek to diagnose, prevent or cure disease. The automobile allows people to travel faster and farther. AI, as a technology, compromises these two basic principles. AI is not meant to solve problems from first principles, but rather to automate or expedite an existing solution. It can seemingly curate a solution that already exists in human knowledge. Therefore, fundamentally, AI, despite its extraordinary value, does not necessarily extend the frontier of human knowledge in the way revolutionary technologies are traditionally expected to do. Its immense value lies in its ability to compress, organise, synthesise and accelerate the vast stock of knowledge that humanity has already accumulated, turning existing knowledge into usable solutions at unprecedented speed and scale. However, it cannot produce an innovative solution that is unknown to mankind. Second, and most ironically,



AI AND YOU. A new world order

AI violates the second premise of technology by eliminating humans from the process itself. Putting robots with agentic AI in manufacturing takes both labourers and managers out of the factory. AI in professional services is not primarily designed to improve the productivity of lawyers, accountants, analysts or programmers; its commercial attraction lies precisely in reducing the need for them. This raises an uncomfortable question. If technology progressively removes humans from production, decision-making, creativity and even social interaction, at what point does technological progress begin to undermine the very human welfare it was supposed to enhance? Extend the logic a little further, and it is not difficult to imagine that such unabated development would compromise the state’s interests as well. Therefore, the state’s recent awakening to the perils of AI industries probably reflects those concerns, triggered by recent cybersecurity threats. Further, AI can diffuse rapidly

through software, cloud computing and open models. Its proliferation is consequently much harder to contain. A teenager can access a powerful AI model. A company can deploy an agent. A foreign actor can distribute a model globally. The barrier to entry is dramatically lower. The state, therefore, faces a dilemma. It has historically encouraged technological competition on the assumption that superior technology ultimately produces superior outcomes for society. Therefore, the race for increasingly powerful AI may contain a paradox: the more successful the race becomes, the more it may undermine the human role that gives the technology its social purpose. A historical parallel is nuclear technology. During the Cold War, technological competition encouraged states to build increasingly destructive arsenals. Eventually, States recognised that no one could meaningfully win an unlimited nuclear race. The logic of technological superiority had become self-defeating. Regulation, arms control and non-proliferation followed. AI is obviously not nuclear technology, and the comparison should not be overstated. But the underlying logic is relevant. A technology race can become socially destructive when the private incentive to develop greater capability diverges from the collective interest in controlling its consequences.

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✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Food security Apropos ‘Kharif Concerns’ (Sept 23). The looming threat of a deficient monsoon and shrinking paddy acreage demands immediate, pragmatic action, rather than complacency rooted in our comfortable buffer stocks. While we may have enough grain to avoid a full-blown food crisis, we cannot ignore the painful reality facing farmers, who are squeezed between rising retail prices and stagnant wholesale returns. A balanced way

forward requires the government to temporarily prioritise food security over fuel blending by reducing the allocation of rice for ethanol production. Furthermore, we must aggressively promote millets and less water-intensive crops through better procurement and market support. **K Chidanand Kumar** Bengaluru

Bank for sale This refers to ‘IDBI Bank Sale: Bank Officers’ Body Writes to Leaders of

Opposition, Seeks Intervention’ (Sept 23). It’s intriguing to observe that the government remains hellbent on privatising IDBI Bank Ltd through the back door (via LIC route). So, no wonder if the question arises: who could be the potential buyer/s? Why waste your time and energy over guessing the name/s of the most likely big wigs while the writing on the wall may be more revealing than anything else? **SK Gupta** New Delhi

Billing in rupees This is with reference to ‘Why it’s Time to Scrap Dollar Billing for Local SEZ Deals’ (Sept 23). Allowing transactions within Indian SEZs to be billed in rupees could simplify payments and reduce unnecessary currency exposure. The proposal deserves careful consideration, particularly for technology and service firms operating within the domestic ecosystem. Clear rules are needed so that businesses face minimal compliance uncertainty

while tax and foreign exchange rules remain protected. Banks and regulators should provide a straightforward settlement framework, including transparent conversion and reporting procedures. Rupee billing could reduce transaction costs and make SEZ operations more convenient. Policy changes should, however, be supported by consultation with businesses and banks. **SM Jeeva** Chennai



Effect of a wider EPFO net

Protects existing jobs; does not create new ones

Sagari Gupta

The Cabinet raised the mandatory wage ceiling for coverage under the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation from ₹15,000 to ₹25,000 a month on September 16, 2026, effective the next day. The government expects the revision to the ceiling, the first since September 2014, to add more than 51 lakh workers to mandatory provident fund, pension and insurance cover. Read as a policy output, that number is real. Read as a policy outcome for India's labour market, it measures something else entirely: how many people already in salaried jobs are now formally registered, not how many new salaried jobs exist.

The new ceiling also sits close to what a typical salaried worker already earns. Average monthly earnings for men in regular wage or salaried employment stood at ₹24,217 in 2025, according to the National Statistics Office's Periodic Labour Force Survey Annual Report. For women in the same category, average earnings were ₹18,353. Both figures fall inside the ₹15,000 to ₹25,000 band, the exact segment the Cabinet says will now come under compulsory coverage. This means the expansion largely captures workers who were already earning close to, or above, the old ceiling, not workers moving into new kinds of formal work. A worker hired last month at ₹20,000 a month was legally outside mandatory EPF coverage. From September 17, the same wage brings automatic enrolment. The job has not changed. Only its treatment under the law has.

THE CHANGE IN CEILING Measured against its own history, the ceiling rose 66.7 per cent in nominal terms. Annualised over the 12 years it stayed frozen, that works out to close to 4.3 per cent a year, below the 5.8 per cent and 7.2 per cent nominal wage growth recorded for male and female regular salaried workers between 2024 and 2025 alone. The ceiling has caught up with wages accumulated since 2014. It has not overtaken the pace at which those wages are currently rising.

The estimated annual government outgo is ₹11,339 crore, against existing budgetary support of ₹10,250 crore, and ₹56,696 crore over five years. That is public money spent on retirement security for workers who already hold salaried jobs. It does not answer a separate



EPFO MEMBERSHIP. Not a proxy for job creation

question: whether India is creating enough new regular jobs to begin with. That question has a clearer, less encouraging answer. Regular wage or salaried employment accounted for 23.6 per cent of India's workforce in 2025, up from 22.4 per cent in 2024, per the same PLFS report. Self-employment remained the largest category, at 56.2 per cent of workers, most of it outside any employer-employee relationship and therefore outside EPFO's reach. The share of workers with a formal salary slip grew by little more than one percentage point in a year. EPFO already administers funds for 7.98 crore contributing members across 7.68 lakh establishments, one of the largest social security systems in the world. The 51 lakh addition, by comparison, is a single rule change applied to a base already inside the formal wage economy.

India has few high-frequency outcome indicators for salaried employment, which is precisely why an output indicator like EPFO membership gets read as a proxy for job creation. The two are not interchangeable.

Unemployment data sharpen the point. Overall unemployment rate eased to 5 per cent in August 2026, a six-month low, according to the NSO's Periodic Labour Force Survey monthly bulletin, which measures activity over the seven days preceding the survey. Urban unemployment, measured on the same basis, held at 6.8 per cent, roughly unchanged from July. Cities, where regular salaried jobs concentrate, continue to show the weakest labour absorption in the country. A wider EPFO net changes little for a worker who cannot find a job to be enrolled into.

India's formalisation story is an output story before it is an outcome story: deeper protection for jobs that already exist, not more of the regular jobs a growing labour force needs.

The writer is an independent public policy consultant

Cyber resilience in banking sector

NEW CHALLENGE. The Reserve Bank of India has its task cut out. Real time information sharing has to be operationalised



MANVI KHANNA

Artificial Intelligence (AI)-enabled cyberattacks have emerged as the leading perceived cybersecurity risk over the next year, according to the RBI's recent Financial Stability Report. Agentic models like Claude's Mythos series can autonomously expose vulnerabilities in a financial institution's infrastructure that might otherwise go undiscovered. These models reduce the time and skill required by an attacker, thereby making cyberattacks more scalable and potent.

The potential for misuse has already led to access restrictions through US government directives and deliberate restrictions by frontier AI providers. It is reasonable to speculate that such restrictions are temporary, with many restrictions already rescinded and models being launched in the public domain. It is only a matter of time before many more actors, including bad actors, gain access to such capabilities.

In this context, this piece examines how AI is reshaping the cyber risk landscape in the banking sector.

MAKES THE PROBLEM WORSE The banking sector is one of the most frequent targets for cyberattacks. Neither the RBI nor the financial institutions are new to managing cyber risk. What triggers alarm bells about Mythos-like models is the possibility that the financial infrastructure is under-defended and the scale at which harm could materialise if vulnerabilities are exploited. Not only are the likelihood and severity of a cyberattack unknown, but there is also uncertainty about whether cyber defences that have

worked till now will hold up against emerging threats.

AI-enabled cyber risks are heightened for financial institutions as they are embedded within a deeply interconnected ecosystem of fintechs, technology providers and other third parties, extending the attack surface beyond their own walls. The 2024 ransomware attack on C Edge Technologies, a core technology service provider, temporarily disrupted payment systems across 300 cooperative and rural banks, leaving customers unable to withdraw cash at ATMs or use UPI. This interconnectedness magnifies the asymmetry between the attackers and the defending financial institutions. An attacker may need to find just one vulnerability in shared infrastructure to cause significant harm, while the bank must defend against every one of them.

A RESILIENCE-BASED APPROACH Financial institutions have limited control over when, where, and how an AI-enabled cyberattack will occur. Therefore, to minimise the severity and consequences of harm, the focus must extend beyond anticipating every attack to ensuring they can withstand and recover from one. A resilience-based approach in cybersecurity recognises this uncertainty as an integral part of decision-making, thereby making it less unsettling. It expects defenders to learn from real-world data and recalibrate their responses through monitoring and feedback.

An attacker may need to find just one vulnerability in shared infrastructure to cause significant harm, while the bank must defend against every one of them

If one were to stress test institutional resilience against AI-enabled cyber risks, the RBI's FREE AI Committee Report found that only one-fourth of respondents had formal processes in place to mitigate AI-related incidents or failures. Of the 127 entities that reported use of AI, only 14 per cent conducted regular audits, only 18 per cent maintained audit logs and 14 per cent conducted real-time performance monitoring. By that measure, the answer to building the banking sector's cyber resilience today cannot rest on individual institutions only.

BUILDING SECTORAL RESILIENCE No single institution will have the visibility, data or capability to anticipate and prepare for every unknown threat. This is coupled with considerable variation across banks, NBFCs, and microfinance institutions in terms of technological maturity, operational capacity and financial resources.

The RBI has already begun to respond to risks arising from agentic and frontier AI models. For instance, the recent Draft Guidance on Model Risk Management requires banks to safeguard models against cyber risks. The recent Cybersecurity, Technology: Risk, Resilience and Assurance Framework Directions, 2026 require financial institutions to dynamically incorporate lessons learnt from past incidents, tests and drills to improve response plans. However, regulatory expectations from financial institutions alone may not suffice. This is where ecosystem-level solutions become important.

First, operationalise real-time information sharing among financial institutions in coordination with the Computer Security Incident Response Team- Financial Sector (CSIRT-Fin). Sharing information on cyberattacks, near-misses or incidents involving non-financial partners, such as technology providers, would give all

institutions timely intelligence to anticipate and prepare for a similar threat. Such a mechanism is more likely to work if reporting is non-punitive, a practice commonly followed in aviation. For instance, the NASA Aviation Safety Reporting System encourages pilots, maintenance technicians, air traffic controllers and others to report unsafe occurrences, close calls and hazardous situations by making such reporting confidential.

Second, use intelligence generated from this mechanism to develop a catalogue of AI-enabled cyber risk scenarios and plausible mitigation strategies that financial institutions can use to stress test their systems against. Such a catalogue can be an equaliser, particularly for smaller institutions. It would give financial institutions a view of priority risks, including those initially identified by only one or two institutions. It can provide a common understanding of the risk, the attack vector, potential impact and possible responses for containment, if the risk materialises. One such library of cyber scenarios is maintained by the UK Cross Market Operational Resilience Group, which has recently added scenarios of threat actors using agentic and generative AI to create false employee and customer accounts.

Lastly, set a baseline of resilience standards against AI-enabled cyber risks for all institutions across the banking, securities, pensions and insurance sector, irrespective of size, geographical presence, IT set-up or the perceived risk profile. The Inter-Ministerial Group on the Financial Sector Cybersecurity Strategy, mandated by the Financial Stability and Development Council last year to develop a unified cybersecurity strategy, should use this opportunity to establish this baseline of non-negotiable standards.

The writer is Research Associate, Dvara Research

thehindubusinessline. TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

September 24, 2006

Jitters over proposal to end US sops for Indian jewellery The Indian jewellery export industry is jittery over reported moves in the US to terminate the duty-free entry of its products under the Generalised System of Preferences (GSP) once the current programme gets over on December 31, 2006. The Gem and Jewellery Export Promotion Council had already taken up the matter with the Department of Commerce.

Govt to set up drug banks in 600 districts The Government will set up district-level drug banks in the approximately 600 districts across the country in public-private partnership (PPP). It will also place a proposal before the Cabinet to allot ₹3,000 crore for health insurance of the 26 crore below-poverty-line (BPL) population.

CST phase-out deferred to April The much-awaited phase out of Central Sales Tax (CST) would now begin from April 1, 2007, against the earlier planned date of October 1 this year. The move to put off the starting date of the CST phase-out by six months came in the wake of lack of "convergence" between the States and the Centre over the elements of the compensation package for CST phase-out.

OECD expects global inflation to linger

Craig Stirling

Inflation around the world will be faster than forecast in 2027, an outlook that necessitates more tightening from the US to Australia, the OECD said. In a report released on Wednesday, the Paris-based club of rich countries raised projections compared with June for consumer-price growth in every Group-of-20 economy apart from China and Saudi Arabia. Monetary policy across the globe may have to respond, its officials added.

"Faced with renewed energy price shocks and stronger-than-expected demand pressures, and at a time when inflation is already above target in many economies, central banks need to ensure that underlying inflation

pressures are durably contained," the OECD said in its report. The analysis underscores how the economic impact of the Middle East war unleashed by Trump is now set to endure into the second half of his term in office.

"Our main message is that central banks have to remain very vigilant," OECD Chief Economist Stefano Scarpetta told Bloomberg Television's Vonnice Quinn. "They need to intervene like they have done so far, perhaps more than what they did in 2022."

The OECD's assessment follows a round of tightening this month, with the US Federal Reserve, the European Central Bank and Bank of Japan all raising interest rates within little more than a week of each other. The organisation's officials reckon more

such action is in the offing, while suggesting it won't match the aggressive policy moves seen in the wake of the 2022 Russian invasion of Ukraine.

MORE FED RATE HIKES It predicts one more hike this year by the Fed, "further modest increases" in the euro area, Australia and South Korea, and "additional policy rate increases" in Japan. By contrast, the OECD says that the Bank of England and the Bank of Canada will keep rates steady for now.

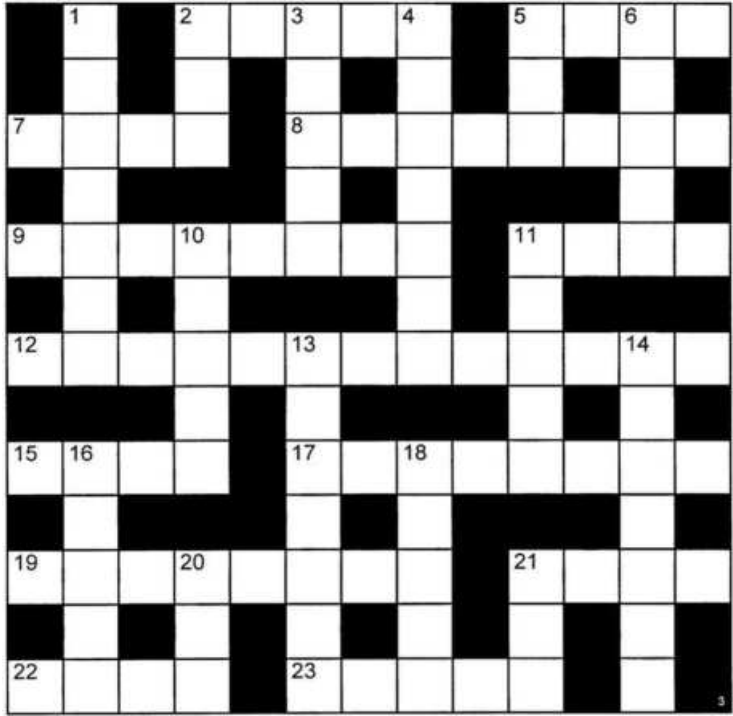
That jars slightly with the views of investors. Money markets are almost evenly split on whether the Fed, ECB and BOE will deliver one or two more hikes by the end of this year. However,

traders are more certain that the BOJ will move just once more by then, and they also favour the BOC to raise rates by a quarter point in that period.

The path of global growth is roughly unchanged compared with June, according to the OECD. Standing out from modest adjustments to its forecasts are downgrades the outlooks for Canada, which faces a trade war with the US, and France, where a period of political instability looms.

"Global economic prospects remain heavily dependent on whether a durable resolution to the Middle East conflict is achieved," the OECD said. "Continued changes in trade policies, both tariffs and export restrictions, add to policy uncertainty and contribute to supply disruptions."

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EASY

ACROSS

- Put tacking stitches in (5)
- A man-eating monster (4)
- Portent, sign (4)
- Metal fencing (8)
- Easily duped (8)
- Repaired and refitted (11)
- Not as much (4)
- Wandering off (8)
- He minds the flock (8)
- Island of the W Indies (4)
- Faithful (4)
- To twine together (5)

DOWN

- Estimate, calculate (7)
- Prohibit (3)
- Wash using hard brush (5)
- Clear to the mind, obvious (7)
- Sash worn with kimono (3)
- A daughter of Lear (5)
- Appears as if (5)
- Subject to emotional changes (5)
- Pudding, afters (7)
- Raise to rank of lord (7)
- An anaesthetic (5)
- Straight lines from centre to circumference (5)
- Dish baked with a crust (3)
- To sever (3)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- What cook may do to joint, sewer may do to material (5)
- He's monstrous, and there's nothing will make Reg change (4)
- A ring given to people as a sign (4)
- Make liar sing : 'They fence me in' (8)
- Easily taken in by the bulge ill-distributed (8)
- Underground workings of explosive laid at sea (4)
- The state the East has when in the red may be renewed (11)
- It isn't so much a word of subtraction (4)
- Is remaining right inside, or is wandering off (8)
- He is a man who is perhaps crooked (8)
- Young creature with a following in the West Indies (4)
- Loyal toast begins on the street in France (4)
- Oliver would call for card to be dealt face-up (5)

DOWN

- Work out how one will arrive, only to be put inside (7)
- Prohibition applies to three-quarters of the musicians (3)
- There's little in the way of vegetation, so clean it (5)
- Dive over a tangled net, as is plain (7)
- The redbreast neither started nor ended with a sash (3)
- Daughter in tragedy, for example, raced around (5)
- How one views one's handsomeness (5)
- There's nothing to do up in my setting, blowing hot and cold (5)
- Is provided with hair and turned over, of course (7)
- Raise one from the common state of Noel and Ben, perhaps (7)
- Extraterrestrial approaching woman might put her out (5)
- Air I'd arranged with some lines from the circle (5)
- Dish for 19 to find in happier situation (3)
- Make less of a rake-off (3)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2741

ACROSS 1. Gallop 8. Agora 9. Melodic 11. Romantic 12. Strew 15. Fino 16. Tub 17. Obey 19. Hedge 21. Molehill 24. Earlier 25. Floor 26. Kitten
DOWN 2. Avert 3. Looker-on 4. Pair 5. Naval 6. Foot 7. Banc 10. Corpuscle 12. Soft 13. Coverlet 14. Byre 18. Shark 20. Grebe 21. Muff 22. Loom 23. Lack

QUICKLY.

NSE shares to trade on MSEI today



Mumbai: Shares of the National Stock Exchange (NSE) will be admitted for trading on the Metropolitan Stock Exchange of India (MSEI) from September 24, according to an MSEI circular issued on Wednesday. NSE shares will trade on MSEI's capital market segment under the "Permitted to Trade" category. NSE has designated BSE as its stock exchange for listing, with its shares scheduled to debut on BSE on Thursday following its ₹22,568.94-crore initial public offering. Under the permitted-to-trade framework, the company does not execute a listing agreement with MSEI and is therefore not subject to the full disclosure requirements applicable to listed securities. **OUR BUREAU**

Kotak Alts raises ₹5,000 cr from domestic investors

Mumbai: Kotak Alternate Asset Managers has closed its Kotak Yield & Growth Fund at ₹5,000 crore, raised entirely from domestic investors. The Category II AIF received commitments from institutional investors, family offices and ultra-high-net-worth individuals across India. The fund had raised ₹3,900 crore at its first close in February 2026. It will invest across private credit, real assets and selective growth opportunities, focusing on cash-flow-generating businesses and mid-to-large-sized enterprises. Kotak Alts said it will now focus on deploying the capital across private credit, real assets and growth opportunities. **OUR BUREAU**

3 cheers: Jindal Supreme, SS Retail, Hero Motors jump sharply on Day 1

Our Bureau

Investors in the IPOs of three companies — SS Retail, Hero Motors and Jindal Supreme (India) — have reasons to smile, as all of them made handsome returns on day 1 of listing on Wednesday despite mixed opening. The star performer among them was SS Retail, as the stock listed at ₹624 against the IPO price of ₹424 on the NSE, and rose further to close at a day's high of ₹748.80, giving investors a whopping return of 76.60 per cent on the listing day. On the BSE, the stock opened at ₹639.10 and closed at ₹765.15, a gain of 80.4 per cent, bettering even the NSE closing price. The IPO of SS Retail was subscribed 103 times. The ₹500-crore issue comprised a fresh issue of ₹360 crore and an OPS of ₹140 crore. Jindal Supreme (India) made a return of 35.5 per cent to investors, as the stock got listed at ₹120 and

Motilal Oswal gets SEBI nod to launch custodian service

Our Bureau

Motilal Oswal Custodial Services Private Ltd, a wholly owned subsidiary of Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd (MOFSL), has received approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India to act as a custodian of securities. This will allow the company to offer safekeeping of securities, trade settlement, corporate action processing and regulatory reporting for institutional clients, including alternative investment funds, portfolio management services, mutual funds, insurance companies and pension funds, among others. MOFSL said in a release.. The company will commence operations in last quarter of 2026.

Airtel Money to list on London SE, will declare offer price by mid-Oct

STAKE SALE. Company's existing shareholders will offload their holding through the public issue

Our Bureau

Bharti Airtel's fintech arm Airtel Money on Wednesday said it is going to list the company on the London Stock Exchange (LSE), adding that the offer, indicative price and size range will be disclosed in a prospectus expected to be published early next month. In a filing to the LSE, the company said the final offer price of the initial public offering is expected to be announced in mid-October. "A London listing will underpin our next wave of growth. The opportunity ahead of us is substantial and, importantly, there are many demographic and digital tailwinds within the

markets that we serve," Ian Ferrao, Chief Executive Officer, Airtel Money, said. Digital transaction volumes across the company's footprint are forecast to grow around five-fold by 2031, and therefore, it can capture this opportunity by accelerating conversion of the growing Airtel Africa telco subscriber base, moving users onto Airtel's app where they transact more often, and by broadening the range of products it offers them, he said.

SECONDARY OFFER Ferrao also said the firm has become Africa's largest fintech platform with around 53 million users every month, translating into strong revenue growth and industry-leading margins.



BULLISH ON FUTURE. Post IPO, Airtel Africa, which holds 77.85% stake in Airtel Money, is expected to remain a long-term strategic shareholder

The IPO will comprise a secondary offer of existing shares to be sold by the company's existing shareholders. Airtel Africa owns 77.85 per cent of the company's issued ordinary share capital. In 2021, TPG, Mastercard, the Qatar Investment Authority

and Chimetech Holding acquired minority stakes for total consideration of \$550 million. International Finance Corporation (IFC) has entered into a cornerstone investment agreement with Airtel Money and certain ex-

Demat accounts to top population of Europe, US by 2047: NSDL

Anupama Ghosh

India's depository ecosystem has grown its investor base from 5 crore in 2020 to over 23 crore by 2026, Sameer Patil, Chief Business Officer of NSDL, said at the Association of Investment Bankers of India (AIBI) Mid-Term conference 2026. Patil attributed the surge to technology, which he said had extended capital market participation beyond metro cities to tier-1, tier-2, and tier-3 towns. NSDL currently holds assets worth over ₹550 lakh crore, operates through more than



Sameer Patil, Chief Business Officer, NSDL

57,000 service centres covering 99.9 per cent of pin codes in India and hosts over 1,20,000 issuers on its platform, making it the world's largest depository by issuer count.

ROLE OF REGULATORS On recent developments,

Patil highlighted the launch of DMAT 2.0 during the Global Fintech Festival, describing it as tokenisation of corporate bonds backed by Central Bank Digital Currency, developed jointly by SEBI and RBI. India's capital market history dates to 1875, Patil said, adding that regulatory support from SEBI had been central to attracting both domestic and foreign investors. Looking ahead, Patil projected that by 2047, the number of demat accounts in India could surpass the combined populations of the Americas and Europe. "...we will outburst the investors in the capital markets," he said.

Nippon MF's Sikka sees India as global factory

Our Bureau

Geopolitical tensions, tariffs and disruptions to global supply chains are reshaping capital markets and creating fresh opportunities for India, particularly as multinational companies increasingly look at the country as a manufacturing base rather than merely a consumer market. Sundee Sikka, Managing Director & CEO, Nippon Life India Asset Management, said the forces influencing capital markets were moving beyond conventional economic policy towards geopolitics. Uncertainty over tariffs, ongoing conflicts,

changing global alliances and shifts in energy markets were altering investment and business decisions worldwide. "It's no more 'Make in India', it's 'built for the world in India'," he said at an Association of Investment Bankers of India event here on Wednesday to highlight the growing interest among foreign companies in establishing manufacturing operations in the country. Recalling his recent participation in a delegation to Japan, Sikka said the nature of conversations with Japanese companies had changed significantly. Instead of having to explain India's potential, discussions were increasingly focused on how com-



Sundee Sikka, MD & CEO, Nippon Life India Asset Management

panies could expand their operations in the country.

BROADER INTEREST Interest was also coming from smaller companies, apart from large multinational corporations, indicating a broader reassessment of India's role in global sup-

ply chains, he said. Germany, too, could offer opportunities as manufacturing companies there explore locations outside the country amid changing business conditions, said Sikka, adding that India could emerge as an important destination for manufacturing-related capital. He also pointed to growing strategic and economic engagement between India and other major economies, including Japan and Germany, as an indication of increasing trust in India's economic potential. At home, the growing participation of retail investors is emerging as an important structural change in India's capital markets.

BROKER'S CALL.

Choice Broking

IRCTC (BUY)

Target: ₹560
CMP: ₹464.05
Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation Ltd (IRCTC) continues to strengthen its digital moat by leveraging its exclusive position in online railway ticketing and evolving into a broader mobility platform. E-ticketing penetration reached about 89 per cent of reserved bookings in FY26, indicating a strong digital adoption. The company benefits from a large user base, providing multiple opportunities for monetisation through convenience fees, payments, advertising and cross-selling of travel services. The ongoing premiumisation of passenger travel, driven by a rising AC mix (about 51 per cent) and increasing adoption of Vande Bharat trains, further enhances revenue potential through higher convenience fee realisation. In addition, IRCTC's proposed unified travel platform is expected to integrate rail, air, hotel, bus and tourism services into a single ecosystem, improving customer engagement and retention. These initiatives are expected to drive margin expansion over the medium-term. We value IRCTC at 25x average of FY28E & FY29E EPS and initiating coverage with a 'Buy' recommendation with target price of ₹560. **Optionality:** The launch of unified travel portal, final approval of the payment aggregator license. **Key risks:** Government regulations, deepening UPI penetration, execution risk in new initiatives, and Rail Neer capacity constraints & operational risks.

ICICI Securities

M&M FINANCIAL (BUY)

Target: ₹415
CMP: ₹348.65
Three years into its digital transformation journey, Mahindra & Mahindra Financial Services (MMFS) has successfully embedded its flagship 'Udaan' programme across lending, servicing and collections verticals. By migrating the customer journey from a low-tech high-touch model to a high-tech high-touch one, MMFS has started witnessing tangible operational benefits such as expanded market share at existing dealer counters, an enhanced cross-sell ratio, and a reduction in TAT to 1-2 days vs 8-10 days earlier. Further, leveraging proprietary scorecard model built on over 3 decades of historical data, MMFS expects to stabilise its overall credit cost within 1.3-1.7 per cent in FY27, demonstrating strong structural resilience, despite temporary headwinds from ongoing geopolitical situation. Alongside process enhancements in onboarding, underwriting and collection, MMFS strategically remained focused on capitalising on its extensive customer base of over 12 million clients. We believe, given that the digital optimisation remains an ongoing exercise, the same will likely ensure structural improvement in return ratios, going forward. **Key risks:** Cyclical nature of vehicle finance impacting AUM growth; and spreads sustaining at lower-than-guided levels. We maintain Buy with an unchanged TP of ₹415, basis a 2x Sep'27E BV.

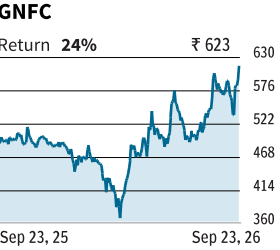
businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: **blmarketwatch@gmail.com**

TODAY'S PICK.

GNFC (₹623): BUY

Gurumurthy K

bl. research bureau
The short-term outlook is bullish for Gujarat Narmada Valley Fertilizers & Chemicals (GNFC). The stock has been moving up very well over the last one week. There is resistance near current levels. But the momentum looks strong. So, there are high chances for the stock to surpass this hurdle. Support is at ₹595 which can limit the downside if the stock turns down from the immediate resistance now. GNFC share price can rise to ₹710-₹720 in the coming weeks. Traders can buy GNFC shares now at ₹623. Accumulate on dips at ₹605. Keep the stop-loss



at ₹575 initially. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹635 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹648. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹655 and ₹680 when the share price touches ₹670 and ₹695 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹705. Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

23455

» Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
23420	23380	23490	23575	Go long only above 23490. Stop-loss can be kept at 23460

₹739

» HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
733	726	743	749	Go short now and at 742. Keep the stop-loss at 744

₹1018

» Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1010	980	1030	1045	Take fresh shorts below 1010 with a stop-loss at 1015

₹270

» ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
268	266	272	274	Go long on dips at 269. Stop-loss can be kept at 267

₹236

» ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
234	232	238	242	Go long now and at 235. Keep the stop-loss at 233

₹1246

» Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1240	1230	1255	1275	Go long only above 1255. Keep the stop-loss at 1248

₹992

» SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
990	982	1000	1010	Take fresh shorts below 990. Keep the stop-loss at 992

₹2082

» TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2075	2040	2110	2150	Go short on a break below 2075. Keep the stop-loss at 2085

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers

	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
Bajaj Finance	1043.20	20.15	31.46	2.61
L&T	3929.90	16.24	27.55	4.29
Reliance Ind	1248.00	11.22	19.16	7.86
Bharti Airtel	1833.20	10.63	30.68	5.20
Tata Steel	190.82	10.57	21.15	1.47
Hindalco	1003.80	9.74	13.75	1.35
ITC	270.15	9.16	16.77	2.43
State Bank	994.10	6.41	10.23	3.83
JSW Steel	1297.80	6.31	11.34	1.13
Apollo Hosp	969.50	5.25	60.04	2.07
Grasim Ind	3188.50	4.97	19.07	1.12
Sun Pharma	1865.00	4.30	36.93	1.84
PowerGrid Corp	2770.20	4.21	15.81	1.14
UltraTech Cement	11155.00	4.01	38.35	1.23
NestleIndia	1387.20	3.65	70.19	0.93
Hind Unilever	1950.00	3.14	43.66	1.61
Bajaj Finserv	1846.50	2.92	14.32	1.00
Adani Ports	1807.30	1.98	31.74	1.24
Shriram Finance Ltd	1010.80	1.47	21.01	1.32
TataConsumerProduct	994.30	1.45	59.92	0.60
Eicher Motors	7470.00	1.29	35.52	0.96
Maruti Suzuki	12230.00	1.14	26.83	1.49
JS Financial Services Ltd.	232.15	1.04	74.36	0.71
Eternal Ltd.	342.65	1.03	763.67	2.31
Kotak Bank	413.25	0.97	20.25	2.84
Bajaj Auto	11400.00	0.90	27.58	1.18
Tech Mahindra	1557.00	0.75	29.56	0.92
ONGC	236.90	0.65	6.65	0.86
Asian Paints	2455.00	0.64	46.68	1.03
ICICI Bank	1240.00	0.63	16.98	0.95
Max Healthcare	1059.90	0.55	70.78	0.74
HDFC Life	561.50	0.54	61.35	0.56
SBI Life	1760.00	0.36	67.88	0.74
Axis Bank	1243.20	0.31	13.84	3.33
Tata Motors PV	300.50	0.21	0.00	0.59
Dr Reddy's Lab	121.00	0.10	31.76	0.29
Int'l GlobeAxi	5028.50	0.07	0.00	1.06
Cipla	1383.00	-0.14	33.29	0.73
Adani Enter	2993.20	-0.24	51.83	0.80
Trent Ltd.	2774.00	-0.65	81.51	0.86
Wipro	164.90	-0.65	12.29	0.42
Bharat Elec	396.05	-1.45	47.09	1.32
Coal India	424.55	-1.81	8.39	0.95
M&M	3035.00	-1.85	18.64	2.53
NTPC	326.00	-1.86	11.16	1.44
HCL Tech	1256.70	-3.16	19.56	1.23
TCS	2089.60	-3.44	15.10	1.99
Titan	4880.00	-4.38	75.22	1.88
HDFC Bank	737.25	-4.52	13.76	10.52
Infosys	1020.50	-6.82	13.65	3.34

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers

	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
Divis Lab	9624.00	100.46	87.35	4.91
Tata Motors Cv	450.20	61.30	39.60	3.77
Vedanta	271.00	39.42	6.35	1.84
Jindal Steel	1175.30	36.92	44.26	1.75
United Spirits	1441.00	36.91	62.13	1.71
Samvardnamoshinternat	164.40	33.77	38.09	2.91
Bajaj Holdings	11449.00	33.22	14.17	1.99
Canara Bank	126.00	30.28	5.76	1.70
AvenueSuper	3834.80	27.07	81.80	2.48
Varun Beverages	456.15	24.44	43.27	2.39
Torrent Pharma	4985.00	23.31	87.95	2.93
Hindustaneronautics	4836.00	19.85	34.70	3.68
Indian Hotels Co.	743.70	19.01	45.85	2.62
Cholamandalam&Fin	1774.00	18.73	26.30	3.08
Cummins India	5010.00	18.65	58.67	2.71
Rural Elec	311.50	15.97	5.12	1.56
Macrotech Developers	1162.50	14.91	28.13	1.29
Pidlifind	1558.10	13.87	60.40	1.97
Bank Of Baroda	236.87	13.59	6.66	1.76
Tata Capital	350.05	13.09	27.12	0.71
Punjab Natl Bank	118.30	13.01	6.14	2.63
Bpcl	315.75	12.66	8.00	1.57
Shree Cement	22500.00	11.66	49.62	1.21
Union Bank	180.00	11.23	6.66	0.39
Hdfc Amc	2448.30	10.84	35.60	2.00
Ambuja Cements	392.75	10.60	18.82	0.98
Dfl	675.00	10.25	37.58	1.74
Tata Power	369.00	9.69	22.43	2.47
Gul India	172.95	8.70	11.52	1.87
WiproHoff	2664.50	7.79	10.01	1.23
Siemens	3886.00	7.19	95.26	1.38
Godrej Consumer	879.75	7.18	47.04	1.42
Hindus Zinc	595.45	6.92	14.74	1.15
Indian Railway Finance Corp	81.00	5.85	14.72	0.65
ZyklusHesciences	1170.10	5.67	25.64	1.17
Indian Oilcorp	138.15	5.49	13.76	1.02
Brittania Ind	4929.00	3.77	45.48	2.33
Mazagon Dock	2211.50	1.66	31.26	0.67
Power Finance	346.00	0.85	3.39	2.02
Abb India	1720.00	-0.08	97.02	1.50
Adani Energy Solutions	1380.00	-1.62	53.64	1.82
Cg Power & Ind Sol	895.00	-2.19	133.85	2.46
Hyndai Motor India	2095.00	-2.49	34.38	1.20
AdaniGreenenergy	1300.90	-3.02	99.85	1.75
Tvs Motor Cmp	4135.00	-3.41	54.55	3.90
Siemens Energy India	3214.40	-5.29	76.93	1.14
Bosch	47955.00	-8.44	59.85	1.67
Solar Industries	19730.00	-11.33	87.07	1.93
Luminore	4085.00	-18.78	23.22	1.52
Adani Power	204.80	-26.05	27.18	3.41

Pts: Impact on index movement

QUICKLY.

Copper falls from record highs on profit taking



London: Copper prices fell on Wednesday under pressure from a stronger dollar and profit taking after the metal tested technical resistance above \$14,800 a tonne. Benchmark three month copper on the LME was down 0.6 per cent at \$14,655. Aluminium slipped by 0.2 per cent to \$3,258. **REUTERS**

Crude oil near 2-week low as supply concerns ease

London: Crude oil prices held near their lowest in more than two weeks as improving Gulf crude supplies weighed on the market. Brent crude futures rose 37 cents at \$99.62 a barrel by 0958 GMT. US WTI futures lost 44 cents to \$90.08. **REUTERS**

Exporters seek reciprocal measures for agri imports

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Some Indian exporters have sought unit-specific approval for exporters from other countries while permitting the import of agricultural produce in the country.

“This comes as they face rejection of rice consignments by China on the alleged presence of genetically modified organisms (GMOs). More countries are now regulating rice imports from India by granting rice mill-specific approval.

India’s food regulator, the

Gold may come under pressure in Q4

HAWKISH FED. Analysts see a firm dollar and elevated US real rates restricting near-term upside for the precious metal

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Gold prices have probably peaked and will be under pressure in the fourth quarter this year as the strength in the dollar meets a hawkish US Fed policy, say analysts.

“The US Federal Reserve (Fed) raised rates for the first time in three years at its September meeting, to the detriment of gold. While falling slightly below the near-term psychological resistance level of \$4,400/oz, prices have well respected the support level at \$4,000/oz,” said research agency BMI, a unit of Fitch Solutions.

“For the next 2-3 quarters, the hawkish policy stance of Developed Market (DM) central banks, a firm US dollar, and elevated US real rates could constrain near-term upside for gold,” said Elara Capital.

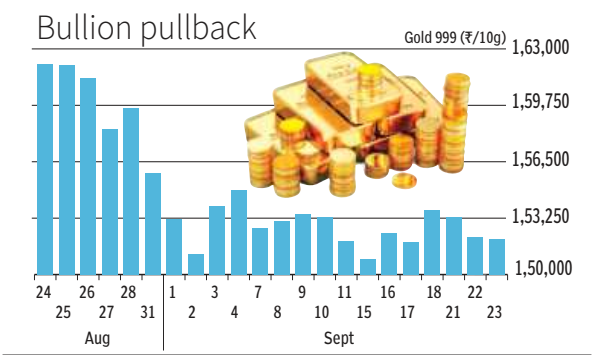
DEMAND SEEN DOWN
“Gold demand is expected to

fall in 2026, as investors take profits and higher dollar bond yields and a stronger dollar reduce gold’s attractiveness,” said Australia’s Office of the Chief Economist (AOCE).

“Gold could remain vulnerable if policymakers signal rates will stay higher for longer,” said ING Think, the economic and financial analysis wing of Dutch multinational financial services firm ING. Gold prices will largely continue to fluctuate within a range. Short-term strength can be viewed as the market having fully priced in the negative news, said Chinese commodity data group SunSirs.

Gold prices have eased as markets braced for central banks to hold rates elevated longer to tame inflation, even as China’s gold imports through August already exceeded full-year 2025 levels, said Prithviraj Kothari, MD, RiddiSiddhi Bullions and President of India Bullion and Jewellers Association.

Gold has slipped as traders priced in the growing



likelihood that major central banks will hold rates higher for longer in their fight against sticky inflation, said Renisha Chainani, Chief Research Officer at Augmont.

PRICE FORECAST

BMI said its Country Risk team expects the Fed to hold rates steady till the end of the year. It could cut rates by 50 basis points in 2027. “This is likely to place a firm floor under gold in the coming months into 2027, despite having peaked in January 2026,” it said.

“We maintain our 2026 gold price forecast at an an-

nual average of \$4,400 per ounce,” said the research agency.

Elara Capital expects gold to trade in the range of \$4,200-4,700/ounce for the rest of the calendar year.

AOCE said prices are forecast to remain high in 2026 and 2027 before falling slowly to around \$4,000 in 2031.

NEAR-TERM VOLATILITY

Darshan Desai, CEO, Aspect Bullion & Refinery, said global interest rates, the dollar and geopolitical developments will continue to drive near-term volatility. “We ex-

pect the (gold) market to remain range-bound and closely watched in the weeks ahead,” he said.

On Wednesday, gold was down by over \$50 to \$4,305 an ounce. Gold December Futures were \$4,342. In India, gold in the Mumbai spot market ended at ₹1,52,016 per 10 gm, up from ₹1,51,407 on Tuesday. On MCX, gold December futures ruled at ₹1,53,989.

Gold has shed all the gains it made this year. It has declined over 20 per cent since it soared to a record high of \$5,608 an ounce in January.

BMI said rate cuts hold the key to interest in gold, as lower bond yields would divert investment into the non-yielding yet haven asset. “All else equal, the larger and more frequent the rate cuts, the greater the upward pressure on gold prices due to its non-yielding characteristic.

Besides, the dollar’s strength, global economy and inflation outlook, and continuing geopolitical risks will dictate the yellow metal’s prospects.

Ahead of Dussehra, Centre despatches onion to Bengal to cool prices

Our Bureau
New Delhi



After releasing 1,400 tonnes of onions to West Bengal for retail sales at ₹35 per kg, the Centre has said it will supply more quantities during the festival season to provide relief to common people.

The next consignment of onion from Nashik via Kanda Express will reach the State on Thursday, it said.

The Department of Consumer Affairs, in a statement, said that the Centre is strengthening onion supply in West Bengal.

The Kanda Express carrying onions from the Price Stabilisation Fund (PSF) buffer stock is scheduled to reach Kolkata on September 24, the department said adding it would be distributed in Kolkata and adjoining districts, particularly ahead of the festival season.

“Around 1,400 tonnes of onions have already been distributed in West Bengal through Nafed and NCCF mobile vans at ₹35 per kg, mainly through road transport. With the arrival of Kanda Express, additional quantities will now be moved more efficiently, helping improve market availability and moderate seasonal price pressures,” it said.

PRICES EASING

In Kolkata, retail sales are currently being undertaken at more than 25 locations, including major markets such as Koley Market, Mechua Mandi, Maniktala Market, Rampuria Market and Shyam Bazar Market.

The government is also exploring the possibility of retail sale of buffer stock onions through Sufal Bangla.

The Centre started the targeted disposal of buffer

Around 1,400 tonnes of the bulb have already been distributed in West Bengal through Nafed and NCCF mobile vans at ₹35/kg

stock through Nafed and NCCF on August 24 and so far, onions from the buffer stock have been supplied to more than 100 cities across the country, the government said.

“The increased availability has also started easing price pressures in several parts of the country. During the past week, retail onion prices remained stable or declined in 17 States and union territories, indicating an improvement in market availability following the buffer stock interventions,” the department said.

It said that prices have declined in Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, Punjab, Tamil Nadu and Bihar during the past week.

The Centre is monitoring onion availability and prices across major consuming markets and is undertaking calibrated releases from the buffer stock.

EUDR norms pose challenge for coffee and rubber growers’ body

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

The United Planters’ Association of Southern India (Upasi), the apex body for the plantation sector, has said that the European Union Deforestation Regulation (EUDR) presents a challenge to the coffee and rubber growers.

It has suggested that the government engage with the EU to seek a practical, proportionate and non-discriminatory implementation of the norms that will come into effect by the end of this year.

Addressing the 133rd annual conference of the trade body in Coonoor on Wednesday, Ajoy Thipaiah, President, Upasi, said the EUDR is more a non-tariff barrier to

trade. “While the European Union has stated that its objective is to prevent deforestation and promote sustainable supply chains, the compliance requirements place a considerable burden on producing countries and small growers. That, however, may be, the enforcement of EUDR — following a couple of deferments — will present significant challenges to India’s coffee and rubber sectors,” Thipaiah said.

“The regulation requires detailed evidence of traceability, geolocation, legality of production and deforestation-free status. Meeting these requirements across thousands of small and fragmented holdings will involve substantial costs, technical capacity and institutional co-ordination,” he added.

Indian coffee and rubber are largely produced by small and medium growers, many of whom may not have access to digital tools, accurate land records or the resources required to undertake complex compliance procedures.

NO DIGITAL ACCESS

There is also a risk that non-compliant growers may be excluded from international supply chains, affecting their incomes and market access, the Upasi President said.

“The immediate need is, therefore, for a co-ordinated national response. Government agencies, the Coffee Board, the Rubber Board, State governments, industry associations and growers must work together to create reliable traceability systems, simplify documentation, support geolocation and

provide affordable compliance services.

“The government should also engage with the European Union to seek practical, proportionate and non-discriminatory implementation. Financial assistance, technical support, capacity building and transitional mechanisms will be essential,” Thipaiah said.

EMBRACE INNOVATION

Further, as we look ahead, the plantation sector must embrace a future that is built on innovation, sustainability and collaboration.

“The future of tea, coffee, rubber and spices will depend not only on how much we produce, but also on how efficiently we produce, how effectively we market, and how successfully we create value,” Thipaiah said.

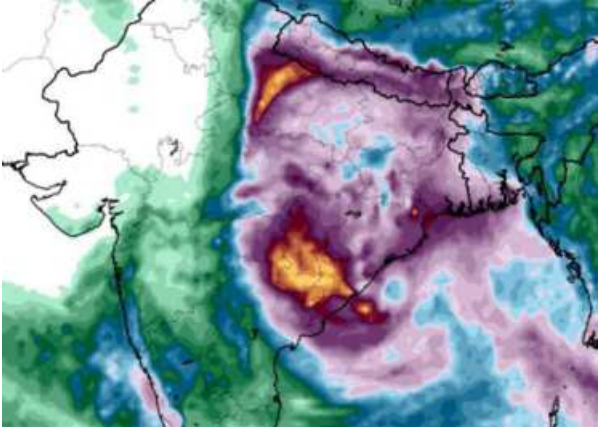
Monsoon withdrawal apace, rains to return

Vinson Kurian
Thiruvananthapuram

The South-West monsoon withdrew from most parts of Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan, the whole of Delhi, and some parts of Uttar Pradesh and Gujarat on Wednesday.

However, a remnant of the rain-bearing deep depression over the Bay of Bengal is likely to move towards the region over the next couple of days, bringing another spell of showers.

The withdrawal line now passes through Gurdaspur, Chandigarh, Muzaffarnagar, Aligarh, Dholpur, Udaipur, Deesa and Naliya. A western disturbance, in the form of a trough, runs roughly along Lucknow and Gorakhpur, while a cyclonic circulation lies over north-west Uttar Pradesh. These systems could interact with the incoming depression and trigger isolated heavy to very



WET PATCH. The deep depression (in purple) could bring very heavy rain over Chhattisgarh and northwards to East Uttar Pradesh

heavy rainfall over the region.

HEAVY RAIN FORECAST

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has forecast isolated extremely heavy rainfall over parts of the South Peninsula and Central India, particularly Telangana, Odisha and Chhattisgarh. Heavy to very

heavy rainfall is also expected at several places across West India, North-West India, and East and North-East India through the weekend.

On Wednesday, the deep depression lay about 60 km south-east of Kalingapatnam in Andhra Pradesh, 140 km east-north-east of Visakhapatnam, 150 km south of Gopalpur in Odisha and

240 km south-southwest of Puri. It was expected to cross the north Andhra Pradesh-south Odisha coasts between Visakhapatnam and Gopalpur, close to Kalingapatnam, as a deep depression by Wednesday night.

The system is likely to move across Uttar Pradesh and subsequently towards Delhi-Chandigarh and Haryana before weakening by Tuesday. This could allow the monsoon withdrawal to resume.

MONSOON TRANSITION

The transition to the North-East monsoon will have to wait until anticyclonic circulations establish over both the Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal and an easterly wind regime develops along their southern flanks. The South-West monsoon must withdraw completely before this transition can begin.

The North-East monsoon normally becomes established by mid-October.

Buy copper futures on a close above ₹1,432/kg

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl, research bureau

Copper futures have been rallying over the past week. The September futures are now trading at ₹1,414/kg whereas the October contract is hovering around ₹1,422. Since the former is approaching its expiry date, we shall consider the latter for analysis and trade recommendation.

COMMODITY CALL.

The October series copper futures rebounded from the support at ₹1,360 last week. While the rally has been sharp and the price has risen above both 21- and 50-day moving averages, the chart shows a resistance ahead at ₹1,432. For the contract to



see another leg of uptrend, it should breach the hurdle at ₹1,432. On such a breakout, copper futures can extend the rally to ₹1,480.

However, if it falls off the resistance at ₹1,432, it can drop to ₹1,400, where the 21-day moving average lies. Support below ₹1,400 is the price band of ₹1,360-₹1,370.

TRADE STRATEGY

Buy copper futures if they witness a daily close above ₹1,432. Target and stop-loss can be ₹1,460 and ₹1,415, respectively.

India ‘commercial front runner’ for agrifood investment in emerging markets: Report

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

The ‘AgTech Investment in Emerging Markets 2025’ report, released by AgBase, Briter and ISF Advisors, places India alongside Brazil, Indonesia, Chile and Argentina in its ‘commercial front runners’ segment.

The markets are characterised by high commercial maturity and strong underlying enablers for agrifood investment.

Based on more than \$4.39 billion in funding between 2023 and the third quarter of 2025, the report tracked 17 markets, with India accounting for \$2.1 billion, the highest among them.

South Asia is the only region studied with a diverse and repeatable set of agri-

food exit routes, spanning corporate and startup acquisitions, private equity transactions and public listings.

Exits occur across on-farm, off-farm and retail segments, indicating that different types of agrifood businesses can achieve scale and generate liquidity for investors.

COMMERCIAL INFLUENCE

South Asia is unique among the emerging-market regions studied in having public listings as part of its agrifood exit landscape, indicating institutional depth and capital markets capable of absorbing agrifood companies, the report said.

The report identifies Ag BioTech as a category whose



investment potential is strongly influenced by commercial agricultural markets, buyers and routes to scale.

While Latin America currently offers stronger commercial routes to scale and exit for biologicals, South and South-East Asia are seeing growing commercial interest alongside continued early-stage capital.

For India, this suggests that the next generation of investable agrifood compan-

ies could increasingly emerge from biology, agricultural inputs, AI-enabled hardware, autonomous drones, robotics and other technologies.

Quoting Mark Kahn, Managing Partner of Omnivore, a media statement said: “Emerging markets have an enormous opportunity to build the next generation of agrifood companies, but what works in one market doesn’t necessarily work in another. India has a rare combination of large agricultural scale, strong digital infrastructure, deep entrepreneurial talent, growing pools of domestic capital, multiple exit routes and supportive government policy. That gives founders a strong foundation to take agrifood businesses from early experimentation to real scale.”

Agrochemical body seeks ₹5,000-7,500 cr support programme for the sector

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Agro Chem Federation of India (ACFI), an association of pesticides manufacturers, has urged the government to introduce a targeted and time-bound policy framework for the sector, including a ₹5,000-7,500 crore support programme for upstream manufacturing. Such a plan will help achieve self-reliance in upstream agrochemical technicals and intermediates, neutralise Chinese advantages in utility costs and promote backward integration, it said.

Releasing a knowledge paper titled “Redefining Indian Crop Protection through Innovation: From Scale to Science”, prepared by KPMG for

the industry body, ACFI said that innovation in agriculture cannot succeed in isolation.

“Biotechnology, crop protection, biologicals, nanotechnology, digital technologies, improved seeds and crop nutrition must converge to create solutions that are scientifically sound, economically viable and relevant to farmers. Equally important is building and preserving farmer trust,” said Kalyan Goswami, ACFI’s Director General.

The KPMG report has emphasised that the objective of the industrial policy should not be permanent protection or subsidy dependence but must focus on correcting clearly identifiable ecosystem disadvantages that reduce manufacturing competitiveness relative to global peers.

QUICKLY.

Avantel bags ₹177-crore satellite gear supply deal

New Delhi: Digital technology company Avantel has bagged a ₹177.35-crore order from Zetwerk Manufacturing Businesses for the supply of satellite communication equipment, the company said on Wednesday. The order has to be executed by March 2027, it said in the regulatory filing. Avantel designs, develops, manufactures, and deploys a wide range of defence electronics products. It also provides after-market support to clients. **PTI**

Synergy, CSL ink pact for shipbuilding projects

Kochi: Synergy Marine Group and Cochin Shipyard Ltd (CSL) signed an MoU to jointly pursue shipbuilding, repair, and conversion projects. The MoU was signed by Ajay Chaudhry, Co-CEO, Ship Management of Synergy Marine Group, and Rajesh Gopalakrishnan, Director (Technical) of CSL, in the presence of Jesper Kristensen, Group CEO of Synergy Marine Group, and Jose VJ, Chairman and MD of CSL. The MoU covers joint business development in ship repair, conversion, newbuilding, module fabrication. **OUR BUREAU**

Division Bench refers plea challenging CEC-EC selection panel to CJI

WRONG SIGNAL. Minister in CEC-EC selection panel *prima facie* fails perception test, says Justice Datta

Krishnadas Rajagopal
New Delhi

Supreme Court Justice Dipankar Datta on Wednesday said the replacement of the Chief Justice of India with a Union Cabinet Minister in the Prime Minister-led selection panel for Chief Election Commissioners and Election Commissioners *prima facie* amounts to an effective veto in favour of the Union government and fails the “perception test”, sending wrong signals to the public. The Judge’s observations came in a separate opinion following a split judgment by a two-Judge Bench over the question whether a challenge to provisions of the Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service, and Term of Office) Act of 2023 ought to be referred to a Constitution Bench or not. Though the two judges differed on the question of reference, they concurred to forward the case to the Chief

Justice of India to ultimately constitute a Constitution Bench of appropriate strength to pronounce an authoritative ruling on the legality of the provisions of the 2023 Act. While Justice Datta did not find a reference to a Constitution Bench necessary, Justice Satish Chandra Sharma, the puisne judge on the Division Bench, held in favour of sending the case to a Constitution Bench. Justice Datta reminded that it is already a well-settled law that independence in the appointment and functioning of the Election Commissioners was integral to free and fair elections and an essential part of the basic structure of the Constitution.

SELECTION CONCERNS “There can be no gainsaying that free and fair elections, to a large extent, depend on a truly independent Election Commission of India (EC). It is not enough for the EC to be independent; it must also appear to be independent,” Justice Datta observed. The Judge said it would be far-fetched to expect a minis-



PANEL PUZZLE. Justice Datta critiques the ministerial role in election commissioner selection, citing independence and public perception concerns. **SUBRAMANIAM S**

ter to defy the wishes of the Prime Minister, leaving the role of the Leader of the Opposition in the three-member selection panel merely “ornamental.” “It would not be a fallacious metaphor to say that since the umpire is picked by the captain of one side in a cricket match and his team wins, even if the decisions made by such an umpire are correct, it carries a patina of suspicion. After all, at the end of the day, the umpire has effectively been chosen by the winning captain,” Justice Datta observed. After all, Justice Datta said, the Prime Minister and his Cabinet Minister shared a

“collective responsibility” under Article 75(3) of the Constitution and worked together in the government. “The inclusion of a Cabinet Minister in the selection committee fails to provide the independent counterweight that a neutral selector could, and he (Cabinet Minister) would merely echo the voice of his leader,” Justice Datta said.

CONSTITUTION BENCH The petitioners had contended that the Act “defeated” a Constitution Bench judgment in the Anoop Baranwal case, which had constituted a selection panel chaired by the Prime Minister and including

the Opposition Leader in the Lok Sabha and the Chief Justice of India. The Anoop Baranwal judgment by a Constitution Bench in March 2023 declared that the CEC should be a person of “fierce independence, neutrality and honesty.” It had called for an end to government monopoly and “exclusive control” over appointments to the highest poll body. Prior to the judgment, the President appointed the CEC and ECs on the advice of the Prime Minister. The judgment brought the appointment process on par with that of the CBI Director. The 2023 Act was passed within months of this judgment. The petitioners, represented by senior advocates Gopal Sankaranarayanan, Shadan Farasat, advocates Prashant Bhushan, Kaleeswaram Raj and Neha Rath, said the Act had bestowed the Executive “dominant control” over CEC/EC appointments. Justice Datta concluded that the petitioners’ apprehensions “prima facie appear to have substance”.

ECI rebuffs criticisms of sidelining officials in SIR, says norms followed

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Wednesday defended itself against the barrage of criticism regarding the Special Intensive Revision of the electoral rolls, including by former electoral officers and politicians, following revelations that two sitting Election Commissioners had flagged concerns 14 times in the last 10 months about not being kept in the loop regarding SIR process. In a detailed statement, the ECI stated that “any operational queries or inputs raised by Commission members during the draft stages are part of standard administrative practice aimed at safeguarding voter rights.”

EC’S DISSENT However, Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Johri, according to *The Indian Express*, objected in writing to not being consulted on decisions regarding the SIR. Realising that Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar was not taking them on board, Sandhu and Johri wrote in July to the Union Cabinet Secretary about the functioning of the Commission. Around that time the two Deputy Election Commissioners — Gyanesh Bharti and Sanjay Kumar — also moved out of the ECI. All official orders, decisions and administrative directions issued by the Commission carry full legal sanctions and follow established statutory procedures under The Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023, the statement read. In recent months, the

Commission stated that it has made numerous decisions, issued instructions, introduced around 40 new initiatives, and undertaken many electoral reforms, including the conduct of electoral roll revisions (including SIR) across the country. All these decisions are the result of the unanimous decisions made by the full Commission over the past year, it added. **FORM 6 CHANGES** Two former chief election commissioners OP Rawat and SY Quraishi, have questioned the SIR process, which has led to 13 crore voters being knocked off the electoral rolls. “This is an unfortunate situation. Such a thing has perhaps rarely happened in the Election Commission. I have also been there, but I saw that decisions were always taken unanimously,” OP Rawat, who was the CEC in 2018, said. **RULE DISPUTE** In one of the many instances of dissent by ECs listed in the published report, Joshi recorded in May that Form 6 could not be changed through instructions issued for the SIR and that the “legally sustainable” course was to amend the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960. Sandhu concurred with him. But a declaration linking new voter applications to the SIR was subsequently introduced in the online Form 6. Sandhu reportedly noted in files in August that the change was “unauthorised and illegal” and should be removed immediately. Former CEC Quraishi said, “If the entire exercise of revising the electoral rolls has been illegal, then you cannot hold an election based on an illegal electoral roll,” Quraishi said.

MoD signs ₹811-crore deal with BDL for 160 SAT-SAAW weapons

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Ministry of Defence (MoD) on Wednesday inked a ₹810.79 crore contract with state-owned Bharat Dynamics Limited (BDL) for the procurement of 160 Satellite Smart Anti-Airfield Weapons (SAT-SAAW) for the Indian Air Force. The contract — under the Buy (Indian-Indigenously Designed, Developed

and Manufactured) category — was signed in the presence of Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh in the national capital. **STAND-OFF STRIKE** SAT-SAAW is an air-to-ground precision-guided glide bomb that can be launched from fighter aircraft such as the Jaguar, Hawk, and Su-30 MKI, and it has the capability to neutralise enemy airfields from a long stand-off range. Indigenously designed



The contract was signed in the presence of Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh in the national capital **ANI**

and developed by the DRDO, the system will have an indigenous content of 60 per cent, along with

the indigenisation of sub-systems such as the Initial Measurement Unit, Long Impact Delay Fuse, and Twin Store Carrier to further boost Atmanirbharta in defence, the Ministry of Defence said in a statement. The Ministry stated that SAT-SAAW will be delivered between 2027-2029. **OPERATIONAL EDGE** The induction of this weapon will enhance the operational capability of

the IAF, as it has the capability to destroy air base infrastructure, reinforced bunkers, and radar installations, without putting the host aircraft in direct danger. The SAT variant uses satellite navigation (GPS/NavIC) integrated with an onboard Inertial Navigation System (INS) to hit stationary targets with high accuracy (typically within 7 meters) in all weather conditions, day or night.

Supra Pacific targets asset base expansion; plans 500 branches

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi

Gold loans are set to remain a key growth driver for Kerala-based Supra Pacific Financial Services as the NBFC eyes a nearly five-fold expansion in its asset base and branch network over the next three years. According to Manoj Ravi, CEO, Supra Pacific, the plan is to scale up the existing microfinance and vehicle-finance operations and also to grow the business lending portfolio through secured working-capital loans of ₹10 lakh-₹1 crore for traders and small businesses. The BSE-listed company plans to expand its presence to 500 branches across 15 States over the next three years. Currently, it has 117 branches in Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra and Goa.

Keralam will remain a key market, with Supra Pacific planning to increase its network in the State to 100 over the next three years, he said. The assets under management have risen from ₹21 crore in 2020-21 to ₹366 crore in the quarter ended June 30, 2026. While total assets stood at ₹511.41 crore at the end of the first quarter of this fiscal year, the company expects the asset base to jump to ₹2,500 crore over the next three years. **GOLD LOAN BIZ** “We saw a healthy growth in our gold loan business in Q1FY27. We will focus on technology deployment and disciplined execution to build a sustainable lending platform with robust asset quality,” Manoj Ravi said. MSMEs have also increasingly turned to gold-backed financing to meet their working capital requirements, he added.

Gujarat puts 63.35 lakh farmers on digital registry; links Aadhaar to land records

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

More than 63.35 lakh farmers have already been registered under the State’s Farmer Registry, which links their Aadhaar-based identity with verified land records. This registry, being implemented under the Centre’s Digital Agriculture Mission (DAM), is aimed at creating a single digital identity for farmers and simplifying their access to government agricultural schemes and services. “With more than 63.35 lakh farmers already registered in Gujarat, the State is continuing the process of registration and integration of farmers’ land records into the digital system,” Jayanti S Ravi, Additional Chief Secretary, Revenue Department, stated in an official release here on Wednesday. The



DIGITAL ACCESS. The registry aims to create a single digital identity for farmers and simplify access to government agricultural schemes and services

Farmer Registry enables eligible farmers to obtain a Unique Farmer ID. **SUPPORT SYSTEM** “The initiative is significant as a move towards transforming the way farmers interact with government schemes and agricultural services,” Ravi added. The Farmer Registry is expected to facilitate beneficiary identification and verification for a range of agricultural pro-

grammes, including PM-Kisan, government procurement under the Price Support Scheme/Minimum Support Price, Kisan Credit Card and agricultural credit, besides various subsidy and farm assistance programmes. Gujarat’s Agriculture Minister Jitubhai Vaghani said, “Once registered and approved, a farmer’s identity and land records are digitally integrated, creating a trusted digital profile. This

streamlines farmer applications, simplifies beneficiary identification and verification, and enhances transparency, efficiency and accuracy in the delivery of government assistance.” **ONLINE REGISTRATION** Farmers can register through the ‘Gujarat Farmer Registry portal’, with the process involving Aadhaar authentication and verification of farmer and land details. Once the information is verified, a Unique Farmer ID is generated and linked to the farmer’s land records. Farmers can also update their records through the Update Farmer Request (UFR) facility if any land survey number is missed during the initial registration. Registration is available online as well as through village-level Panchayat offices, VCEs, Gram Sevaks and Common Service Centres.

CIAL strengthens Far East link with four more weekly services to Bangkok

Our Bureau
Kochi

Cochin International Airport’s connectivity to key international and domestic destinations with new services marked in this year’s winter schedule. This includes four weekly services to Bangkok by Air India Express; daily link to Fujairah by IndiGo; and to Dubai, Dammam and Kuwait by Akasa Air.. On the domestic sector, IndiGo will operate daily services to Kolkata and Thiruvananthapuram. The winter schedule commencing from October 26 to March 28, 2027 features a total of 1,766 scheduled weekly flight movements, comprising 885 arrivals and



The Bangkok service will be operated by Air India Express.

881 departures. The schedule connects Kochi with 32 airport destinations — 13 domestic and 19 international by 28 airlines, with an average of around 252 scheduled flight movements a day. CIAL already has connectivity to Bangkok-Don Mueang, Kuala Lumpur,

Singapore, Male and Colombo, with the existing schedule providing 93 weekly arrivals from six South and Southeast Asian destinations. **REGIONAL CONNECTIVITY** S Suhas, Managing Director, CIAL said, “We have plans to

further enhance the passenger experience, including services such as home baggage collection and improved facilities for passengers requiring special assistance,” he said. **WINTER SCHEDULE** The airport’s winter schedule will further connect Kochi with 13 airports across the Gulf region, including Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Doha, Kuwait, Riyadh, Muscat, Sharjah, Jeddah, Bahrain, Dammam, Fujairah, Ras Al Khaimah and Salalah, accounting for 327 weekly arrivals. CIAL’s domestic network comprises 13 destinations and 465 weekly arrivals, with Bengaluru, Mumbai, Delhi, Hyderabad and Chennai among the destinations by frequency.

Union Finance Minister, AP CM to break ground for horticulture hub on Oct 2

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu and Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman will lay the foundation for the Rayalaseema horticulture hub at Madanapalle on October 2. The Centre will provide ₹40,000 crore under the Purvodaya scheme for the project and another ₹60,000 crore is expected to come through private companies to develop the hub. The project will be implemented across the four undivided districts of Rayalaseema as well as Prakasam and Nellore districts.

The project aims to promote horticulture-related activities in drought-prone areas and strengthen the region’s agricultural economy. The foundation stone for the Indian School of Agriculture, which will be backed by Reliance, will also be laid.

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thehindu **businessline.**

BEFORE THE HON'BLE NATIONAL COMPANY LAW TRIBUNAL, CHANDIGARH BENCH, AT CHANDIGARH

COMPANY PETITION NO. CP(CAA) No. 26/CHD/HR/2026
CONNECTED WITH
CA (CAA) NO. 16/CHD/HR/2026
AND
TP NO. 3/CHD/HR/2026
(TRANSFERRED FROM CHENNAI BENCH,
CASE NO. CA (CAA) NO. 46/CHE/2026)

IN THE MATTER OF SECTIONS 230-232 AND OTHER APPLICABLE PROVISIONS OF THE COMPANIES ACT, 2013 READ WITH COMPANIES (COMPROMISES, ARRANGEMENTS AND AMALGAMATIONS) RULES, 2016
AND
IN THE MATTER OF COMPOSITE SCHEME OF ARRANGEMENT AMONGST

SUNBEAM LIGHTWEIGHTING SOLUTIONS LIMITED
A company incorporated under the Companies Act, 2013 having its registered office at Plot Nos. 75 to 79 and 94 to 98, Sector-59, Phase-II, Ballabgarh, Faridabad, Haryana-121004, India
...Petitioner Company No. 1/ Transferee Company / Amalgamated Company

SUPRASH DEVELOPERS PRIVATE LIMITED
A company incorporated under the Companies Act, 2013 having its registered office at No. 7 Othappai Village, Uthukkottai Taluk, Odappai, Tiruvallur, Tamil Nadu-602023, India.
...Petitioner Company No. 2/ Transferor Company No. 1/ Amalgamating Company No. 1

SRIKARA TECHNOLOGIES PRIVATE LIMITED
A company incorporated under the Companies Act, 2013 having its registered office at No. 7 Othappai Village, Uthukkottai Taluk, Odappai, Tiruvallur, Tamil Nadu-602023, India.
...Petitioner Company No. 3/ Transferor Company No. 2/ Amalgamating Company No. 2

DR AXION INDIA LIMITED
A company incorporated under the Companies Act, 1956 having its registered office at No. 7 Othappai Village, Uthukkottai Taluk, Odappai, Tiruvallur, Tamil Nadu-602023, India.
...Petitioner Company No. 4/ Transferor Company No. 3/ Amalgamating Company No. 3

NOTICE OF HEARING OF THE COMPANY PETITION FILED BEFORE THE HON'BLE NATIONAL COMPANY LAW TRIBUNAL, CHANDIGARH BENCH

A joint second motion petition bearing Company Petition No. C.P.(CAA) No. 26/Chd/Hr/2026 under Sections 230 - 232 read with the Companies (Compromises, Arrangements and Amalgamations) Rules, 2016 and other applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 (“**Joint Petition**”) seeking sanction of the composite scheme of arrangement amongst Sunbeam Lightweighting Solutions Limited (“**Petitioner Company No. 1**”), Suprash Developers Private Limited (“**Petitioner Company No. 2**”), Sri Kara Technologies Private Limited (“**Petitioner Company No. 3**”) and DR Axion India Limited (“**Petitioner Company No. 4**”) (collectively “**Petitioner Companies**”) and their respective shareholders and creditors (“**Scheme**”) was filed on 22.08.2026 and was admitted by way of an order dated 25.08.2026 by the Chandigarh bench of the Hon'ble National Company Law Tribunal (“**Hon'ble Tribunal**”) and the **Hon'ble Tribunal** has fixed the hearing for the Joint Petition on **29.10.2026** (Thursday), before the Hon'ble Tribunal. Any person concerned with the Petitioner Companies desirous of supporting or opposing the said Petition, should send to the Hon'ble Tribunal and the Petitioner Companies’ advocate, at the below-mentioned address, notice of his/her intention, signed by him/her or his/her advocate/authorised representative, with his/her name and address, so as to reach the Hon'ble Tribunal and the Petitioner Companies’ advocate not later than 2 (two) days before the date fixed for the hearing of the Petition, i.e. **29.10.2026**. Where such concerned person seeks to oppose the Petition, the grounds of opposition or a copy of his/her affidavit in that regard shall be filed with the Hon'ble Tribunal at Corporate Bhawan, Plot No. 4-B, Ground Floor, Sector 27-B, Chandigarh - 160019 and a copy thereof shall be furnished on the Petitioner Companies’ advocate at the address mentioned below. A copy of the Petition will be furnished by the undersigned to any person requiring the same on payment of prescribed charges for the same.

M/s Sagus Legal LLP
Attn : Ms. Shruti Kanodia,
Managing Partner.
Advocate for the Petitioner Companies
Address: B-7/8, Ground Floor, Block B7, Safdarjung Enclave, New Delhi, Delhi - 110029
Email: service@saguslegal.com

QUICKLY.

Anthropic, OpenEvidence to bring medical AI

Anthropic and medical knowledge platform OpenEvidence are collaborating to bring AI-powered clinical decision support to physicians in regions without access to the technology, the companies said on Tuesday. The new initiative is a specialised version available to healthcare providers for free in dozens of low- and middle-income countries where limited access to medical literature, specialist expertise and continuing medical education can impair patient care. REUTERS

US FDA clears Glenmark's Goa unit with VAI status

New Delhi: Drug maker Glenmark Pharmaceuticals Ltd on Wednesday said it has received an establishment inspection report from the US health regulator for its manufacturing facility in Goa. The inspection was closed with a voluntary action indicated (VAI) status, the company said in a regulatory filing. VAI classification indicates no regulatory action required despite objectionable conditions were observed. PTI

IPL 2027 auction to be held in Goa, likely on Dec 15-16



New Delhi: The Indian Premier League (IPL) 2027 auction will be held in Goa in December, its chairman Arun Dhimal told PTI on Wednesday. The auction is returning to India after three editions were conducted overseas. "We have finalised Goa. The likely dates are December 15 to 16," said Dhimal. PTI

‘India should invest in foundational AI R&D’

MONOPOLISATION TACTIC. Zoho Founder says he is cynical about frontier model makers suddenly calling for slowing AI progress

bl.interview

Sindhu Hariharan
Rohan Das
Chennai

Zoho Founder and Chief Scientist Sridhar Vembu has called for India to channel its AI investments into foundational R&D rather than large-scale GPU infrastructure. Such research could eventually evolve into digital public infrastructure, he says.

Speaking to *businessline* at the launch of Zia Chat, a single conversational AI interface for businesses to work across apps, and announcing Zoho's foray into vertical SaaS, the founder says India business has seen robust growth but rising data centre costs and AI token costs are a strain on margins. Vembu also played down the calls from frontier model makers to slow AI

progress and says he views them cynically.
Excerpts:

Is there slowdown in SaaS? How has Zoho's growth been?
Considering the Middle East situation and other geopolitical issues, our growth globally has been a little slower this year compared to last year but we are still growing. In India, business has grown by around 45 per cent. Our costs are definitely going up. Data centre expenses have gone up nearly 4X compared to a year ago at a similar level of customer growth. Moreover AI usage is also adding an additional layer of token costs. These affect margins.

How has SaaS pricing evolved? Is the seat-based model still relevant?
Right now, we are still sticking with a seat based model

Despite the rising costs, we have not raised the prices as we are counting on productivity gains in usage of AI

SRIDHAR VEMBU
Chief Scientist & Founder, Zoho

because the customers seem to prefer it. Over time, we plan to evolve into API or outcome-based model. But, despite the rising costs, we have not raised the prices as we are counting on productivity gains in usage of AI. But, I cannot rule out a price rise in future.

Zoho entered the hardware segment its server Nathu La earlier this year. Will you get into more AI hardware



areas?
We have a lot of internal demand right now and we are trying to meet all of it efficiently. Given memory prices have shot up drastically, we do not want to start selling our servers in the market right now. We expect the economics will shift over time.

Long-term we definitely intend to supply [our servers] to other companies, but first we have to satisfy our own data centre needs.

In today's complex AI world order, where should India direct its investments?

We should not bother ourselves with large scale investments in infrastructure such as GPUs. Our capital should go towards foundational AI-related R&D focused on healthcare, education and other public needs that can eventually become digital public infrastructure like UPI and benefit people at scale. I have seen some really good proposals from labs at IITs and IISC in this area.

Some frontier labs have called for slowing AI development? What's your view?

I am a bit cynical about this. I believe these companies want everybody else to slow down so that they can move faster and can monopolize the market. The problem

now is that LLMs are becoming a commodity. It is a real risk for them as they are no longer able to justify the huge valuations. That is probably why they are calling for a slowdown.

In the age of AI, what happens to entry-level jobs, especially in markets like India?

We should not look at software jobs alone. Building medical equipments, defence and aerospace solutions - all of these are jobs for youth. I would look at launching a national effort to build jet engines, advanced materials, and other areas. As a country, nothing is off limits with our demographics. Yes, we [Zoho] have not been hiring many software engineers. But, with our verticalisation play, we are also repurposing our engineers to work with customers to translate domain specific needs in the software.

‘Global HQs hold reins on tech workforce hiring, layoffs’

Our Bureau
Bangaluru

Oracle reduced its workforce by about 21,000 employees in its last fiscal year, with India estimated to account for more than half of the decline. In a survey of 1,467 India-based professionals by Blind, the anonymous community app for professionals, 44 per cent of respondents whose reporting line reaches a VP or higher in India say the final decision on headcount cuts is made outside the country.

Among companies with VP-level or higher leadership in India, workers most often say hiring and firing decisions are made outside the



FIRING LINE. On Blind, an Oracle professional said Indians were hired for cost advantage and later cut first because it was “cheaper and legally quieter”

country at PayPal (65 per cent), Salesforce (59 per cent), Visa (58 per cent), ServiceNow (50 per cent), Uber (48 per cent) and Oracle (46 per cent).

The share is lowest at Amazon (25 per cent), Qual-

comm (25 per cent) and Adobe (33 per cent). Many multinationals run their India teams on a matrix, often with a dotted line to a local site leader and a solid line to a global function owner.

Several companies at the

top of the list have cut jobs in India this year, in decisions made at the global level. PayPal confirmed 220 layoffs in India in August.

Visa reportedly laid off hundreds of employees in India. Uber's global cut of about 3,300 roles reportedly hit 200-250 employees in India.

LIMITED SAY

Oracle's latest round of layoffs in September has reportedly hit up to 3,000 employees in India out of more than 6,000 globally. On Blind, an Oracle professional said Indians were hired for cost advantage and later cut first because it was “cheaper and legally quieter”.

A senior leader in India

does have a say on hiring, but not much on layoffs. Among workers whose reporting line reaches VP or higher in India, 39 per cent say new roles are approved abroad, down from 46 per cent across all respondents. For cuts, the share barely moves: 44 per cent, compared with 46 per cent overall.

SENIOR LEADERSHIP

The pattern extends beyond companies with senior leadership in India.

Across all respondents, 46 per cent say the final call on headcount cuts is made outside India, by a global function owner or by finance or HQ, compared with 36 per cent who say it is made within India. For new roles,

46 per cent say approval sits abroad, compared with 39 per cent in India.

For more than half of India's tech workforce, there is no senior leader in the country to begin with. Fifty-three per cent say their India reporting line ends at manager or director level (40 per cent) or that their team has no India reporting line at all (13 per cent). For teams with no India reporting line, around 75 per cent say hiring and firing decisions are made outside the country.

Many workers don't know who makes the call at all. Fifteen per cent say they don't know who approves a new role on their team, rising to 18 per cent when it comes to cuts.

Pfizer India removes products from Karnataka amid counterfeit drugs probe

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai

Pfizer India has removed products from the market whose batch details were copied by counterfeiters, the multinational drugmaker said, on recent investigations into spurious drugs by Karnataka's drug regulatory authority.

Earlier this week, the Karnataka Food Safety and Drugs Administration (FSDA) had reportedly cancelled the licences of 16 pharmaceutical retailers and wholesalers, and suspended eight others, including that of a Pfizer depot.

In fact, State Health Minister UT Khader had been quoted in the media saying, they had “stopped Pfizer's sale in the State because they did not cooperate with the investigation”.

Responding to a query



from *businessline*, Pfizer said, “We have been working together with the authorities through the past one month when the matter of counterfeit medicines was brought to our attention. Since then, we have taken several actions to support the investigation, including removing, from the market, Pfizer batches (where batch numbers were copied by counterfeit) to avoid confusion, supporting to differentiate between original and coun-

terfeit product, and providing technical and other relevant information related to the affected batches.”

The company added, it was working with the authorities “to resolve the open queries”.

PROBE UNDERWAY

Investigations are underway on whether the spurious drugs crackdown in Karnataka had leads to any other state, a regulatory representative said.

The State was already investigating a fake drugs racket where cancer and other critical medicines were allegedly sold to hospitals and clinics.

Hospital representatives, who did not want to be named, said that reputed institutions source medicines from registered companies with legit supply chains. While they advocate track and trace systems including

barcodes, they caution, rouge elements can still infiltrate the system.

RECENT RAIDS

The Karnataka incident comes on the heels of regulatory raids in Gujarat and New Delhi, last month.

In August, an inter-state fake drugs network was busted after counterfeit blood pressure drug (Nicardia Retard) was seized in Gujarat by the Ahmedabad Crime Branch and State Food and Drugs Administration (FDA). The fakes were reportedly flagged by JB Chemicals after products carrying its branding but not made by it were found in the market.

In a separate incident, the Drug Controller General of India flagged a fake rabies vaccine batch in Delhi carrying the same branding and batch number as an Indian Immunologicals' vaccine.

FSSAI proposes to implement labelling rules for front of the pack in single phase

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has proposed to implement the front-of-the-pack warning labels (FoPL) framework with a single-phase approach, according to sources. Under the proposed framework, once implemented, food companies will be required to display front-of-the pack warning labels if their products breach the prescribed threshold for any one nutrient of concern, which are added sugar, fat and salt.

It has also proposed to give a period of one year to packaged food companies for voluntary implementation for transition to the front-of-the-pack labelling framework post its notification.

In its submissions to the Supreme Court, a copy of

which was seen by *businessline*, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has said that it proposes to adopt “a single-phase approach” for the implementation of “Front-of-Pack Nutrition Labelling.” It added that a period of four months will be reasonably required for following the regulatory process , which involves issuing and finalising the draft regulations.

HEXAGON LABEL

“FSSAI is proposing a red Hexagon with white square shaped background FoPL format, drawing similarity, more or less, with the FoPL format adopted by Canada. Furthermore, where only one nutrient of concern is present, the corresponding nutrient shall be indicated in the hexagon. Where two or three nutrients of concern are present, the applicable two or three nutrients shall



also be indicated within a single hexagon, thereby providing clear and specific information to consumers,” it has stated in its filings submitted to the Supreme Court, which is hearing the matter.

The FSSAI is also mandatorily required to publish the draft regulations for consultation process with stakeholders. The food safety regulator has submitted that there will be “voluntary implementation period of 365 days by Food Business Operators (FBOs).” It said that a

minimum transition period of 365 days from the date of the notification of the amendments in labelling regulations is provided to ensure food companies do not face commercial hardships. Food companies typically keep packaging materials printed in advance and in bulk and hence any labelling changes are done after giving a period of transition to packaged food companies.

WARNING STATEMENT

The regulator has also proposed that food products including beverages that contain “non-caloric sweetener” to have a warning statement on the front of the pack stating, “Contains Non Caloric Sweetener”, as per its submission to the SC.

In its earlier submission, the food safety regulator had proposed to adopt a two-phased approach for the implementation.

Marvell to double India semicon R&D as AI needs shift

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

Marvell Technology will use its planned \$250 million investment in India over the next three years to double its R&D capabilities, with a significant portion of the capital going towards new laboratories, validation infrastructure, and engineering talent as the semiconductor company steps up work on AI infrastructure.

In July, the data infrastructure semiconductor solutions provider announced plans to invest in expanding its capabilities across technology, talent, and infrastructure.

As part of this investment, Marvell plans to double its headcount over the next three years and is unveiling a new wing at its Bengaluru office while expanding its presence in Hyderabad. The ex-

panded footprint will strengthen the company's global innovation network, supporting the design and development of advanced semiconductor solutions for AI, cloud and data infrastructure applications.

“We intend to double our R&D capabilities. There are three perspectives to this: One is what we do from a CAPEX perspective — the new facilities, new labs, and other things that we bring in, so that we have the space to work and, secondly, the right tools, instruments, and infrastructure to work,” said Navin Bishnoi, VP and India Country Manager, Marvell Technology.

The lab will not be limited to chip design, but will also include final validation and qualification facilities. Marvell plans to use benches, servers and other infrastructure to recreate customer environments and validate



Navin Bishnoi, Vice-President and India Country Manager, Marvell Technology

silicon at the board and system level, including embedded hardware and software. This will form a significant part of the CAPEX investment and be part of its validation and productisation lab.

HUMAN CAPITAL

Another part is human capital for R&D. “We forecast doubling the headcount and are doing so aggressively. We are progressing fast in the

first year itself,” Bishnoi shared. Marvell has over a few thousand employees in India, forming one-fourth of the global headcount.

The third component of the investment will focus on expanding Marvell's research and technology ecosystem through universities and startups, including projects involving early prototypes and IP creation.

More than 90 per cent of Marvell's employees in India are engineers working on chip and product development.

“There are two elements to Marvell's portfolio. One is the whole product — we build compute, switches, networking, interconnect, storage, security, and all those things. We have an R&D team here contributing to these products.

The other is the building block or foundation for product development — what the next-generation techno-

logy, IP, tools, and software will be, how EDA will look, and how we build all of this. We have a team working on this foundation to enable products that will go out into the market.”

AI OPPORTUNITY

Marvell has R&D teams working across different product cycles, with some focused on products due to reach customers in the short term and others looking further ahead at the technologies and requirements that will underpin the next generation. This spans both its central engineering function and individual product development teams.

Marvell's India expansion comes as the company sees a significant opportunity in AI infrastructure, where the focus is shifting from general-purpose compute towards custom silicon and networking.

UP top draw for tourists followed by Tamil Nadu, Rajasthan: Survey

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Uttar Pradesh got maximum number of visitors coming for pilgrimage, shopping, etc, from both within and outside the State as it recorded highest share in total visitor trips, Domestic Tourism Expenditure Survey report by Statistics Ministry released on Wednesday said.

The survey was conducted during July 2025 and June 2026 among 2.46 lakh households all over the country except villages in Andaman & Nicobar Islands.

OVERNIGHT TRIPS

“Combining visitors both from within the state and from other states, Uttar Pradesh accounted for the highest share in total visitor



trips (15.7 per cent), followed by Tamil Nadu (13.4 per cent) and Rajasthan (8 per cent),” the report said.

On other findings, the report said number of overnight trips generated per 100 households reporting at least one overnight trip (tourist household) during last 365 days was — 127 per 100 rural tourist households (118 per 100 rural tourist households in 2014-15) and 132 per 100 urban tourist households (121 per

100 urban tourist households in 2014-15).

Both the sectors reported ‘pilgrimage & religious’ as the highest share with around 48 per cent followed by ‘health and medical’ purposes in rural areas and ‘holidaying, leisure & recreation’ in urban areas.

Around 80 per cent of visitors preferred to stay for five days or less during their overnight trips. May and October were the peak months for domestic overnight trips undertaken for holidaying, leisure and recreation purposes during the last 365 days.

Health and medical trips incurred maximum expenditure in both rural areas (₹29,454) and urban (₹41,649) areas among all the trips completed during the reference period.

